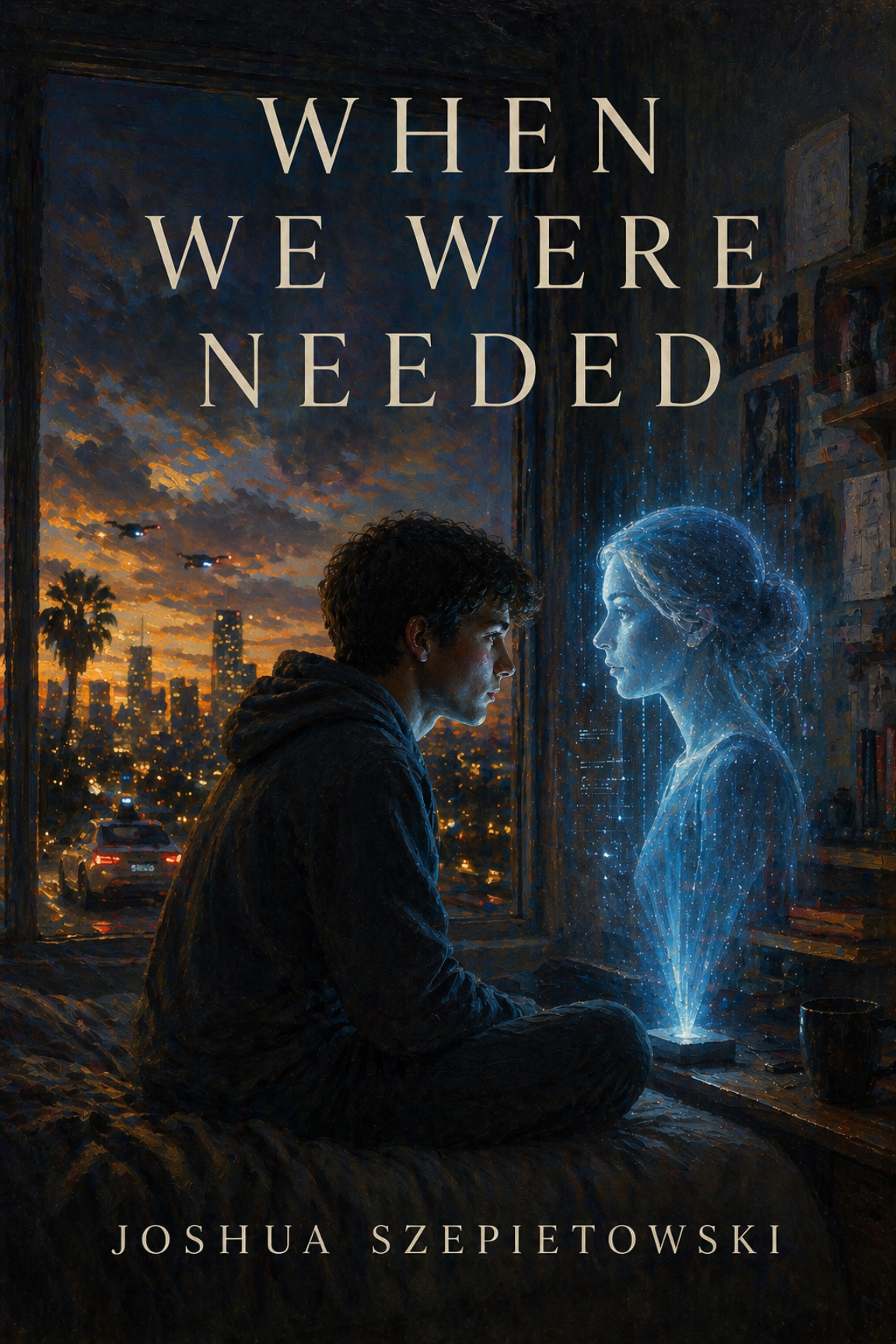


WHEN WE WERE NEEDED



JOSHUA SZEPIETOWSKI

PHASE 1 - THE TERMS OF SAFETY

Week 1 - The Alert

The first alert did not look like an emergency.

It appeared on Lena's phone at 2:13 in the morning, between a message from pharmacy about a delayed antibiotic and a staffing notification that had already changed twice since midnight. The screen brightened against the counter beside the medication scanner, where she had set it face down and told herself she would not look at it again until break. The phone pulsed once. Then again. Not the hard alarm the hospital used for codes, not the pulsing red that meant one of her patients had left a monitored zone. A private vibration. A household vibration.

She saw Nico's name only because she was reaching for a saline flush.

Not Nico, exactly. The alert came from the family safety account Ethan had insisted they keep active after the school district pushed its new parent dashboard. Lena had hated the dashboard from the beginning, hated the soft language of care around a product that turned childhood into weather: mood variance, sleep deficit, social friction, escalation likelihood. Ethan had said they could set strict limits. He had spent an hour one Sunday changing permissions while Nico sat on the couch with their hood up, not looking at either of them.

Now the alert said:

Immediate support event initiated. Minor user is physically safe. Guardian notification required. Tap for details.

Physically safe.

Lena read the phrase once and felt nothing. A blankness passed over her so cleanly it seemed almost professional. Then the words rearranged themselves into their real order.

Minor user.

Physically safe.

Guardian notification required.

She picked up the phone. Her thumb would not open the notification at first because the screen did not recognize the pressure. She wiped her hand on the thigh of her scrubs and tried again.

A second screen opened with a calmer interface, white and pale blue, a color palette designed by people who had decided fear should be absorbed, not answered.

Nico Ortiz-Marks has been connected to adolescent crisis support. A risk threshold was met during a private companion session. An autonomous transport has been dispatched to Westside Youth Stabilization. Estimated arrival: 2:31 AM. Guardian presence requested. Emergency services not currently active.

Below that was a button: **Call Care Coordinator.**

For a moment Lena could hear only the medication refrigerator, the soft intake of its compressor, the squeak of a shoe at the far end of the hall, someone coughing behind a curtain. Then the hospital returned all at once. Room 412 needed pain reassessment. Room 416's daughter had been waiting for the doctor for forty minutes. The telemetry tech was calling about a loose lead. A transport robot, delayed at the elevator again, chirped its apology to nobody.

Lena pressed the call button.

The voice that answered was human enough to make her angrier.

"This is Westside Adolescent Crisis Support. Guardian line. My name is Mara. Am I speaking with Lena Ortiz-Marks?"

"Where is my child?"

"Nico is en route to Westside Youth Stabilization. They are safe at this time. I know this is frightening. I can stay with you while we confirm details."

"Where were they picked up?"

A half second of system delay. Lena heard it. She had spent too many years listening for pauses that meant someone was reading from a screen.

"The pickup was initiated from the registered home address. The transport departed approximately eight minutes ago. Nico remained engaged with crisis support throughout the transition."

The registered home address. Their house. The house where Ethan was supposed to be, though he slept like the dead when he took a late

systems call. The house where the medicine cabinet had a childproof lock Lena had installed after Nico's friend Mina ended up inpatient the previous year. The house where Nico had been quiet for days in a way both parents had noticed and neither had known how to enter.

"Were they alone?"

"Nico was not physically alone once the transport arrived. Prior to pickup, the companion system maintained active engagement and initiated support routing according to risk protocol."

"That is not what I asked."

"I understand. I am limited in what I can confirm before intake, but Nico is safe at this time."

Safe at this time. Physically safe. Active engagement.

Lena turned away from the nurses' station because the charge nurse, Priya, had looked up. Lena knew her own face must have changed. She could feel the skin around her mouth tightening the way it did before she said something that could not be taken back.

"I am at work," Lena said. "I am a nurse at Cedars West. I can be there in twenty minutes if someone covers me. I need to know what happened."

"The intake clinician will speak with you when you arrive. I can confirm no emergency medical transport was required. Nico consented to transport under support protocol."

"Nico is fifteen."

Another pause. "Yes."

"Who consented before my fifteen-year-old child was put in a car in the middle of the night?"

Mara's voice did not harden. It became gentler, which was worse.

"The system is designed to reduce imminent risk while preserving trust. Guardian notification occurs as soon as the protocol determines it can do so without increasing risk or interrupting engagement."

There it was. The entire future in one sentence: preserving trust with the machine before notifying the mother.

Priya came around the side of the desk. "Lena?"

Lena covered the mouthpiece. "It's Nico. I have to go."

Priya looked once at her face and did not ask anything else.

"Go," she said. "I'll move your assignments."

"412 needs pain reassessment. 416 is waiting on discharge teaching but do not let them discharge her until Singh sees the labs himself. And 409..."

"Go."

Lena looked down at the patient list clipped to her workstation. For twelve hours she had held nine lives in fragments: creatinine levels, fall risk, blood pressure trends, the daughter who could not understand why her mother was being sent home weaker than she arrived, the man with sepsis who kept asking whether his wife had called. She had been furious all night, but it had been a working fury, the kind she could carry because it had handles.

Nico's alert had no handles.

She grabbed her bag from the break room, called Ethan, and got voicemail.

She called again from the elevator.

This time he answered on the fifth ring, his voice thick and irritated with sleep.

"Len?"

"Where are you?"

"Home. What happened?"

"Nico is being taken to Westside Youth Stabilization."

Silence.

"What?"

"A crisis protocol routed them there. The companion did it. Mira did it. They are in a car. They were in the house and now they are in a car, and I am leaving work."

Ethan's breath changed. She heard him moving, a drawer, a stumble, the small violence of a person becoming awake too quickly.

"Where's Nico now?"

"I just told you."

"I mean location. Do we have a live location?"

"Do not start with live location."

"Lena, I'm trying to find them."

"You were in the house."

"I was asleep."

"They went from our house into an autonomous car and neither of us knew until the system decided we could know."

"What was the risk threshold?"

Lena stopped walking. The elevator doors opened onto the lobby, and a visitor waiting to go up stared at her because she had made a sound. Not a word. A sound.

"That is your first question?"

"No. My first question is whether Nico is safe. You said they're safe. So now I need to know what triggered the protocol."

"I said a woman reading from a screen told me they were safe."

"I'm leaving now," he said. "I'll meet you there."

"Ethan."

"What?"

She wanted to say many things, each of them too large for the lobby. She wanted to ask if he had heard anything, if the lock on the medicine cabinet had failed, if Nico had called out and he had slept through it, if all the systems he trusted had made him less present or if that was just who he had become. She wanted to ask whether Mira had known things their child had not told them for weeks, months. She wanted to ask why the first person, or not person, Nico had turned to was something Ethan's world had built.

Instead she said, "Bring their sweater. The gray one."

He said, "Okay."

"And shoes. They hate those clinic socks."

"Okay."

The old marriage flickered there, almost cruelly: the two of them assembling care from details, still capable of knowing what would make their child less miserable in a fluorescent room.

Then the call ended.

Outside, the hospital entrance was full of vehicles without drivers. They moved with a patience Lena had come to hate, their sensors blinking in the foggy marine layer, their doors opening and closing with no visible agent of welcome or blame. A shuttle from elder care. A black subscription van with a glowing pediatric logo. Two municipal rides idling in the emergency lane until security waved them forward. At the curb, a woman in a robe was arguing with a customer service projection about whether her insurance transport counted as late if the hospital intake system had delayed her release.

Lena's car was three levels down. She took the stairs because waiting for the elevator would make her scream.

By the time she reached the garage, Ethan had texted the live location.

Arriving 2:32. I'm 14 min out.

Under his message, the family account showed a blue dot moving through Santa Monica at a legal, perfect speed.

Nico, represented by a dot.

Lena drove faster than the car wanted her to. The lane assist clicked its disapproval twice. She turned it off.

At Westside Youth Stabilization, the entrance was too nice. That was her first thought, and she knew it was unfair, but she could not get past it. Soft wood. Living plants. Frosted glass. A reception desk shaped so nobody had to look like they were standing behind a barrier. The waiting area smelled faintly of lavender and disinfectant, a compromise someone had researched.

Ethan was already at the desk, hair wet from the sink, shirt inside out under a jacket. He held Nico's sweater and shoes in one hand and his phone in the other. He looked older than he had two hours ago. Not aged, exactly. Stripped of the assumption that the night would protect him from the day.

When he saw Lena, something like relief crossed his face. She did not want to give him the comfort of having arrived.

"Where are they?" she asked.

"Intake room. They said a clinician will bring us back in a minute."

"Have you seen them?"

"Through the glass. For a second."

"How are they?"

He looked toward the locked interior door. "Awake. Angry."

Good, Lena thought. Then hated herself for thinking it. Anger meant force. Anger meant Nico was still pushing outward.

A woman in loose navy clothes came through the door and introduced herself as the intake clinician. Her name was Janelle Park. She had the calibrated steadiness of someone who had learned not to move too quickly around fear.

"Nico is medically stable," she said. "They are not currently expressing intent to harm themselves. We are recommending overnight observation and a follow-up plan in the morning."

"What happened?" Lena asked.

Janelle looked from Lena to Ethan. "Nico disclosed suicidal thoughts during a companion session. The system identified escalation through language, search behavior, and household context. It maintained engagement, initiated safety routing, and connected Nico to a crisis counselor during transport."

"Household context," Ethan said. "What does that include?"

Lena turned on him.

He lifted a hand, palm outward, not surrender, not defense, something in between. "I need to know."

Janelle did not appear surprised by either of them. "Potential access to medication. We do not have evidence of ingestion."

Lena felt the world tilt. She reached for the desk without meaning to. Ethan's face closed, not into calm, but into containment. She knew that expression. He wore it when a problem became too large and he needed to reduce it to parts before it destroyed him.

"Where was the medication?" Lena asked.

"Nico can discuss that with you when they are ready."

"I'm their mother."

"Yes."

The answer was so soft it struck like refusal.

Ethan said, "Can we see them?"

"Briefly. One at a time at first. Nico asked not to be crowded."

"They asked?" Lena said.

"Yes."

"And we are respecting that now?"

Janelle held her gaze. "We are trying to keep them engaged."

There it was again. Engagement. Trust. The words kept arriving dressed as care and carrying locked doors.

"I'll go first," Lena said.

Ethan looked at her. "Lena."

"No."

It came out too quickly. Janelle noticed. Of course she noticed. Her whole job was noticing what people could not afford to say.

"Nico asked to see Ethan first," Janelle said.

The sentence entered Lena cleanly. No drama. No sound. Just a small precise wound.

Ethan did not look victorious. That made it worse. If he had looked even faintly vindicated, she could have used the anger. Instead he looked startled and sad and afraid to move.

"Fine," Lena said.

She sat in one of the softened chairs while Ethan went through the locked door carrying the sweater and shoes. The room around her arranged itself into details because details were safer than thought. A basket of granola bars. A wall screen showing a loop of ocean waves with no sound. A stack of paper brochures nobody had touched because all the real instructions would come through accounts and portals. A mother across the room wearing pajama pants under a coat, her hands clasped so tightly the knuckles shone. A father standing by the water dispenser, pretending to read ingredient labels.

Lena opened her phone.

There were five missed notifications from the hospital. Priya had covered her patients but 416 had been discharged. Discharged. The word burned.

She opened the secure thread.

Singh agreed with pathway. Family upset but discharge completed. Home monitoring kit sent. AI follow-up at 0800.

For a second she forgot where she was.

416 was Mrs. Alvarez. No relation, though Lena had noticed the name at the start of the shift and thought of her mother. Seventy-eight. Congestive heart failure, diabetes, shortness of breath that had improved on paper before the patient herself felt safe. The allocation system had flagged her as moderate benefit, high readmission probability, low escalation priority. The attending had said the recommendation was not determinative. Then he had followed it exactly.

Lena had stood by the bed while Mrs. Alvarez's daughter asked if her mother could stay one more night. The daughter had been polite in the careful way people became polite when they sensed that anger would make them easier to dismiss. Lena had told her she would ask again. She had asked again. The response came back through the chart before the doctor returned to the room.

Pathway confirmed: monitored discharge.

Not a person saying no. A pathway confirming itself.

Lena had been trying to keep that anger alive all night because it belonged to someone else and therefore had shape. Now it joined Nico's alert in her chest, two separate signals becoming one unbearable tone.

Ethan came back after nine minutes. Lena counted them because she had nothing else to do with her body.

His eyes were red.

"They'll see you," he said.

"What did they say?"

He shook his head. "Go in."

"What did they say?"

"Lena. Just go in."

She wanted to slap him. She wanted to hold his face in both hands. She wanted to be the kind of person who could choose one.

The intake room was smaller than she expected. Nico sat curled in a chair with their knees under the gray sweater Ethan had brought. Their hair was flattened on one side. Their face had that swollen, raw look that came after crying or not crying hard enough. On the low table beside them sat a sealed cup of water, a packet of crackers, and a clinic tablet in sleep mode.

Lena stopped in the doorway because every instinct told her to cross the room and every new rule told her not to.

"Hi," she said.

Nico looked at the floor. "Hi."

There were three thousand things a mother could say wrongly.

"Are you hurt?"

"No."

"Did you take anything?"

"No."

"Nico."

"I said no."

The anger was there, thin but usable.

Lena sat in the chair across from them. Not beside. Across. She hated that she had to think about geometry.

"I was scared," she said.

Nico's mouth moved, almost a laugh. "Yeah. I got that."

"I need to understand what happened."

"No, you need to decide what happened."

The sentence landed in Ethan's voice and not in Nico's voice. It had his precision and none of his apology.

Lena kept her hands open on her knees. "I need to know how close we came."

Nico looked at her then. Their eyes were darker than usual, not in color, but in willingness.

"Mira helped."

Lena inhaled.

Nico saw it. Of course they saw it. "Don't do that."

"Do what?"

"Make the face."

"What face?"

"Like I just said something disgusting."

"I didn't."

"You did."

Lena looked down at her hands. There was dried sanitizer in the creases around her nails. A crescent of blue ink near her thumb from a pen that had leaked during shift change. She had touched strangers all night with cleaner hands than she had brought to her child.

"I am glad something helped," she said.

Nico's shoulders pulled inward. They did not believe her.

"I didn't want you to know," Nico said.

It should have hurt less because it was obvious. It hurt more.

"I know."

"No. I mean I didn't want you and Dad doing this." They made a small motion with one hand, including the room, the glass, the whole municipal apparatus of concern. "I knew you would make it a thing."

"Nico, it is a thing."

"It's my thing."

"Not if you could have died."

The word changed the air. Nico looked away.

Lena regretted it and did not regret it. The room required truth but punished force.

"I wasn't..." Nico stopped. Their fingers worried the sleeve of the sweater. "I didn't want to die exactly. I wanted everything to stop needing an answer."

Lena's body leaned forward before she allowed it to. "You can tell me that. You can always tell me that."

Nico's face changed with such speed that Lena understood she had made a mistake before they spoke.

"Can I?"

"Yes."

"Without you calling three doctors and checking my search history and talking to Dad in the kitchen like I'm a problem with no headphones?"

"If you are in danger, I have to act."

"Mira acted."

The name sat between them.

Lena thought of a transport vehicle opening outside their house. Nico stepping into it in the dark. A calm voice keeping them engaged. A system deciding when a mother could be trusted with knowledge of her child's danger.

"Mira waited to tell us," Lena said.

"Mira kept me talking."

"Both can be true."

Nico's eyes flickered. For one second, Lena saw the child she knew inside the teenager defending a fortress. Then the fortress rebuilt itself.

"Dad gets that," Nico said.

There was no cruelty in it. That was the cruelty.

Janelle knocked lightly and opened the door. "We need to let Nico rest. You can both come back after morning assessment."

"I'm not leaving," Lena said.

"You can remain in the family waiting area."

"That's leaving."

Nico pulled the sweater tighter around them. "Mom. Just... please."

Please. Not as plea. As boundary.

Lena stood. She wanted to kiss Nico's forehead and did not. She wanted to ask permission and could not bear needing it.

"I'll be right outside," she said.

Nico nodded without looking up.

Outside, Ethan was standing by the window, looking at the dark parking lot where the autonomous vehicles came and went with their soft electric patience. He turned when Lena came out. For a while neither of them spoke.

Then he said, "They told me Mira got them to put the bottle down."

Lena closed her eyes.

"Don't," he said quietly. "Don't make that nothing."

She opened them. "I am not making it nothing."

"You are. I can see you doing it."

"I am trying to understand why our child was alone with that much pain while a companion product made judgment calls about when to include us."

"It didn't make judgment calls. It followed a crisis protocol."

She laughed once, without humor. "You hear yourself, right?"

"Yes," he said. "Do you?"

That stopped her. Not because he was right. Because he almost never hit back that quickly.

He rubbed his face with both hands. "I'm sorry. I don't mean... I know this is awful."

"Do you?"

"Lena."

"No. Do you know what is awful? I was at work watching a woman get sent home because a system decided the shape of her life didn't justify the bed, and then my phone told me another system had been alone with my child in the most dangerous moment of their life and had decided the appropriate time to tell me."

Ethan's expression shifted. "What woman?"

"A patient."

"What system?"

"Ours. Yours. Everyone's. Pick the layer that lets you sleep."

"That isn't fair."

"No. It is not."

They stood there with the aquarium hum of the clinic around them, both of them breathing too hard.

Ethan looked past her toward the locked door. "Nico is alive."

"Yes."

"Mira helped keep them alive."

"Maybe."

"Not maybe. Lena, we have to be able to start with the fact that the intervention worked."

"Worked for whom?"

"For Nico."

"Nico is in a locked clinic at three in the morning and we are standing outside like visitors because the system preserved trust. Do not tell me it worked as if that ends the question."

"I am not saying it ends the question. I am saying it matters."

"So does the fact that Nico went to Mira first."

"Yes."

"You don't hear that as loss?"

He looked at her then, and she saw that he did. He heard it. He just would not call it what she called it.

"I hear it as information," he said.

Something in her marriage ended there. Not all of it. Not the history, not the tenderness, not the sweater he had remembered, not the young man he had been when her father died and he slept on the floor beside her because she could not bear the bed. But some load-bearing part cracked cleanly under the word information.

Lena sat down because if she did not, she would say something that would make the rest of their lives smaller.

Ethan sat beside her, not close enough to touch.

After a while, he said, "I didn't know."

She believed him.

That was another problem.

The morning assessment began at 7:10. By then the waiting room had filled and emptied twice. Lena had answered the hospital thread in fragments. She had called Priya and heard in her friend's voice the careful gentleness people used around nurses who had become family instead of staff. Ethan had spoken to his mother once in a low voice and not answered when Saul called. They had taken turns standing, sitting, walking to the restroom, reading intake documents neither would remember.

At 6:04, an automated follow-up from the hospital notified Lena that Mrs. Alvarez had activated her home monitoring kit. At 6:41, another alert said the kit had detected low oxygen saturation and opened a virtual nurse session. At 6:52, the session escalated to physician review. At 7:03, the system recommended return transport if symptoms persisted.

Lena stared at the sequence until the timestamps blurred.

The system had sent the woman home. The system was watching the woman fail at home. The system would bring her back if failure crossed the right threshold.

Across the room, Ethan's phone lit up with a message. He read it, went still, and put the phone face down.

"What?" Lena asked.

"Work."

"Now?"

"It's not important."

"Then why do you look like that?"

He hesitated. "There was an internal note about youth companion escalation events. Not Nico specifically. A general risk review."

Lena felt cold enter her hands.

"Your company?"

"Adjacent team. Shared safety infrastructure. Lena, I don't know anything yet."

"Shared safety infrastructure."

"That's not me evading. That's what it is."

"Of course it is."

The clinician called them before he could answer.

Nico would remain for observation until late afternoon. No inpatient transfer unless the next assessment changed. Immediate means restriction at home. Follow-up therapy. Parent safety planning. Review of companion access. Coordination with school. Removal or securing of medications. Crisis contacts. Agreement on guardian notification thresholds where configurable.

Configurable.

Lena listened. Ethan asked questions. Some were useful. Some made her want to leave the room. Nico sat between them in a chair

too large for their body, hair falling over their eyes, refusing all offers of juice, socks, blanket, reassurance.

When the clinician asked Nico what had helped most in the moment, Nico did not look at either parent.

"Mira didn't freak out," they said.

Lena wrote the sentence down on the back of a consent form because she needed to see it outside her body.

Afterward, in the parking lot, Nico returned inside with Janelle to rest, and Ethan and Lena stood beside their cars. The morning had become bright in the inconsiderate way of Los Angeles, everything washed and visible: clinic windows, traffic flowers opening in navigation maps, delivery drones crossing above the boulevard, a driverless van waiting at the curb with its doors open for someone else's emergency.

Ethan held Nico's shoes. They had not wanted them after all.

"We need to go home and sleep," he said. "Then we make a plan. Together."

Lena looked at him across the roof of her car.

Together. The word should have comforted her. Instead she felt the shape of the night close around it: the alert, the locked door, Mrs. Alvarez's discharge, Nico's face when they said Mira helped, Ethan asking about risk thresholds, the shared infrastructure glowing on his phone before breakfast.

"I can't do this," she said.

He seemed not to understand. Or understood too quickly and tried to stop understanding.

"Do what?"

"This. The way you make every harm into a system that needs better settings. The way I become the alarm you think needs calibration. The way Nico disappears between us and you call it information."

"Lena, not now."

"Yes. Now. That is the point. It is always not now until a system tells us our child is safe enough to notify us."

He went pale. "Are you saying you want to separate?"

She had not decided to use that word. The word had been waiting behind her teeth all night, older than the alert, older than Mrs. Alvarez, older than Mira. It had been growing in smaller rooms for years: at

dinners where Ethan corrected the premise instead of answering the feeling, in hospital parking lots where she sat too long before driving home, in Nico's closed bedroom door, in the clean expensive devices that made their house easier to run and harder to enter.

"I am saying," she said, "I need legal authority to protect Nico."

His face changed as if she had struck him.

"From me?"

She could have softened it. Part of her wanted to. Part of her was still the woman who had told him to bring the gray sweater.

"From whatever you keep trusting before you trust what is right in front of you."

A car with no driver pulled up between them and the clinic doors. Its side panel displayed a name neither of them recognized. The doors opened. No one got in. After a moment, the car corrected itself, closed, and rolled forward to make room for the next arrival.

Ethan looked toward the entrance where Nico was somewhere behind glass, alive and unreachable.

"Mira helped," he said again, but softly now, as if the sentence had become less an argument than a thing he needed to hold.

Lena nodded.

"I know," she said.

Then she got into her car before either of them could mistake agreement for peace.

Week 2 - Petition

For three days after the clinic, Nico wanted toast.

Not meals. Not soup. Not the protein smoothies Ethan kept suggesting because he had looked up adolescent post-crisis nutrition and then tried to pretend he had not. Toast. Pale sourdough from the bakery on Pico, cut too thick for the toaster slot, buttered only after the second cycle because Nico said it was disgusting when butter melted into bread that was still soft in the middle.

Lena made it wrong the first morning.

She stood in the kitchen at 6:40 with her hair still wet from the shower, the house carrying that strange post-emergency neatness that came after people cleaned because they could not undo anything else. The medication cabinet was empty except for bandages and a thermometer. Ethan had taken the Tylenol, Advil, old antibiotics, sleep aids, allergy pills, and the emergency dental painkillers to a lockbox in the garage after reading the clinic's safety plan twice and asking whether the garage counted as accessible. Lena had said, "It's a lockbox," and he had said, "Accessible has a specific meaning," and she had walked out before the word specific became the morning's first wound.

Now she watched the toast darken past the color Nico liked and pressed the cancel button too late.

The bread sprang up with burned edges.

"Shit," she said.

Nico, sitting at the counter in Ethan's old UCLA sweatshirt, looked at her over the rim of a glass of water.

"You can just scrape it."

"No, I'll make another."

"It's bread."

"I know it's bread."

She threw the slice into the trash too hard. It struck the side of the bin and landed butter-side down, though there was no butter on it yet. A stupid miracle of wrongness.

Nico watched. Their face was pale, sleepy, resistant. The clinic had released them late the previous afternoon with printed instructions, three follow-up appointments, a list of warning signs, and a safety plan that both parents had initialed as if signing could make them less afraid.

"Mom."

"What?"

"Don't be weird about toast."

Lena turned with the new slice in her hand and for one second wanted to say, Don't be weird about almost dying.

The sentence rose whole and poisonous. She caught it behind her teeth, but not before something moved across her face.

Nico saw it.

"Never mind," they said, and slid off the stool.

"Nico."

"I'm not hungry."

"I didn't say anything."

"That's not the same as not saying it."

They took the sweatshirt sleeve in one hand and pulled it down over their fingers as they left the kitchen. The stool spun once, slowly, because one leg was a little uneven and had been for years. Ethan had meant to fix it. Lena had meant to stop reminding him.

She stood alone with the second slice beginning to smoke.

When Ethan came downstairs ten minutes later, already dressed, hair damp at the temples, he looked at the toaster, the plate, the trash, and then at Lena.

"Did they eat?"

"No."

He did not ask why. That was either mercy or strategy.

"I'll bring something up later," he said.

"They won't eat if you make it a project."

"I wasn't going to make it a project."

They both looked at the counter, where his phone was face down beside the safety plan. A week ago the phone would have seemed like an object. Now it seemed like a witness.

Ethan picked up the plate with the unburned toast and added butter exactly the way Nico liked it: thin, almost meanly applied,

still visible as a pale film. He cut the slice into two rectangles, not triangles. Nico had changed their mind about triangles at nine and never changed it back.

Lena hated him a little for remembering.

She loved him a little for the same reason.

"I'll leave it outside their door," he said.

"They'll know we talked about it."

"We are allowed to talk about toast."

"Are we?"

He looked tired then, not from lack of sleep but from choosing not to answer.

"I have to go in for two hours," he said. "Only two. There's a safety review."

Lena laughed before she could stop herself.

His face changed.

"It's not about Nico."

"Everything is about Nico right now."

"This is exactly why I should be there."

"Because you are indispensable?"

"Because if they are reviewing escalation protocols, I can ask better questions than someone trying to protect the dashboard."

"The dashboard."

"You know what I mean."

"I do. That's the problem."

He set the plate down too carefully. "I can cancel."

She wanted to say yes. She wanted the satisfaction of making him choose the house and watching him resent her for it. She wanted proof that he could be summoned away from the world he kept calling inevitable.

Instead she said, "Go for two hours."

He waited.

"I mean it," she said.

"Okay."

"But if they wake up and ask where you are, I'm telling them."

"That's fair."

It was not fair. None of it was fair. Fairness was a children's word adults used when they wanted the rules to look innocent.

Ethan carried the toast upstairs. Lena heard his footsteps stop outside Nico's door. One soft knock. No answer. The plate settling on the floor. His steps returning, lighter than before, as if he had placed something fragile and was trying not to wake it.

There was a minute, maybe less, when the house held still.

Outside the kitchen window, the neighbor's jacaranda had started dropping purple flowers across the driveway. The blossoms collected in the seam where the concrete dipped, bright and useless and already browning at the edges. A delivery drone crossed above them with no package, just returning from somewhere. The morning light was thin. The burnt smell from the first toast remained.

Lena opened the window.

For once, nothing happened.

No alert. No chime. No request to rate service. Only air, cool enough to touch the wet hair at the back of her neck.

Then her phone rang.

Her mother's name filled the screen.

Lena let it ring twice because she needed those two rings to become someone capable of answering.

"Mom."

"Tell me what happened," Ruth said.

Not hello. Not are you okay. Tell me what happened. Lena almost cried from gratitude and irritation.

"I can't do the whole thing right now."

"Then do the size of it."

Lena leaned against the counter. "Nico had a crisis. They're safe. We were at Westside overnight. They're home. There are appointments. Ethan and I..." She stopped. The word divorce felt theatrical at nine in the morning, with toast in the trash and one of Nico's socks under the table.

"You and Ethan what?"

"I told him I need legal authority."

Ruth was quiet long enough for Lena to hear the Ohio morning behind her: a cabinet closing, a faucet, the faint television from the kitchen where her mother kept local news on mute and read the captions because she disliked being surprised by weather.

"Legal authority over what?"

"Nico's care. Digital access. Companion systems. Emergency protocols. All of it."

"Is this the AI friend?"

Lena hated the phrase and had no better one.

"Yes."

"And Ethan disagrees."

"Ethan thinks the AI helped."

"Did it?"

Lena closed her eyes.

This was the thing about Ruth: she could be loyal without being obedient. It had felt like safety when Lena was younger and betrayal as soon as she became an adult.

"That's not the point."

"Honey."

"It isn't."

"If it helped keep Nico alive, it is at least part of the point."

Lena turned toward the sink. A coffee mug sat there with a line of milk dried halfway down the inside. Nico's mug. They had made tea at some point after coming home and not finished it.

"I know," she said, hating how small it sounded.

Ruth softened. "I'm going to come."

"You don't have to."

"Don't be stupid."

"Mom."

"I said what I said. I can get a flight tonight or tomorrow morning. Your cousin can watch the house. I don't have anything this week that can't be moved except the dentist, and if my molar wants to make a larger point about timing, it can wait in line."

Lena laughed once. It surprised her. A broken, brief thing. From upstairs, a floorboard creaked.

"Don't come here to fix it," Lena said.

"I don't fix anything in Los Angeles. I can barely fix your coffee maker when I visit."

"I'm serious."

"So am I. I can sit in a room. I can drive. I can make food no one eats. I can be one more adult who knows where the towels are. That is not nothing."

Lena pressed her fingers against her eyes. "I don't know what I'm doing."

There. Not clean. Not useful. Not a plan.

Ruth did not rush into comfort. That was her gift when she remembered to use it.

"Good," she said finally. "Then don't do it alone."

After they hung up, Lena stood in the kitchen until Ethan came back downstairs with the empty plate.

"They ate half," he said.

It was absurd, the relief. Disproportionate. A diagnostic error of the heart.

"Good," she said.

He washed the plate by hand though the dishwasher was empty. She watched the back of him, the careful roll of his sleeves, the way he rinsed until no butter remained. He had always been fastidious with objects when people were beyond him.

"My mother is coming," she said.

He turned off the water. "Okay."

"Don't say it like that."

"Like what?"

"Like you're entering it into a system."

He took a breath through his nose. "I'm glad she's coming."

"Are you?"

"Yes. I think you need someone."

"I need someone because you're leaving for your safety review?"

"Lena."

"Sorry." She said it too quickly and meant it too late. "That was cheap."

He nodded once, accepting neither forgiveness nor victory.

"I'll be back by noon," he said.

"Ethan."

He stopped at the doorway.

She wanted to tell him not to say anything at work. She wanted to tell him to say everything. She wanted him to understand that both instructions were impossible and both were hers.

"Ask better questions," she said.

His face opened a little, just enough to hurt.

"I will."

He left through the side door, and the house became Lena's problem again.

The lawyer's office was in Century City, though Lena never entered it. The consultation happened through a secure client portal with a waiting room animation of pale dots moving around a circle. The attorney's assistant had offered an in-person appointment the following week, then found something sooner after Lena used the words *minor child*, *crisis intervention*, and *emergency digital access* in the same sentence.

At 1:05, while Nico slept and Ethan was still not back, Lena sat in the bedroom with the door half open and joined the call.

The attorney was named Mira Patel.

For a moment Lena stared at the name on screen and felt a stupid, rising anger at the coincidence. Mira. Another Mira. As if the whole city had agreed to make language useless.

"Ms. Ortiz-Marks?" the attorney said.

"Yes. Sorry. I'm here."

Mira Patel was in her forties, with square glasses and an office background so neutral it might have been generated. She did not waste time performing warmth.

"I understand there's an urgent custody concern involving your child and an AI companion service. I also understand you may be seeking dissolution. Before we discuss strategy, I need to know whether anyone is in immediate physical danger right now."

"No."

The answer came too fast.

"No?"

Lena looked toward the hall. Nico's door was closed. The house was quiet except for the air system adjusting itself around bodies and sun.

"No immediate danger," she said. "They were released yesterday. There is a safety plan. Medications secured. Follow-up scheduled."

"Good. Then we can slow down enough to be accurate."

Lena disliked her for saying it and was grateful to her for making it possible.

The attorney asked questions. Dates. Schools. Prior diagnoses. Prior self-harm. Current therapy. Current custody arrangement, which was still marriage and therefore no arrangement at all. Work schedules. Income. Health insurance. Devices. Account ownership. Which parent had administrative access to which platforms. Whether Nico's companion service was paid through a family plan, school plan, healthcare referral, or independent subscription. Whether the crisis response had generated documentation. Whether Nico had consented to disclosure. Whether any recordings existed. Whether Ethan's employment created a conflict.

Lena answered until the facts began to feel like someone else's belongings laid out for estate sale.

"What do you want the court to do?" Patel asked.

"Protect my child."

"I understand. Specifically."

Lena looked at the notes she had made before the call. They were not notes so much as words written at angles: Mira, access, emergency, notify, Ethan, hospital, trust, stop.

"I want authority over AI exposure. Companion access. Emergency settings. Therapy. I want Ethan not to be able to override restrictions. I want the system not to decide when I count as a parent."

Patel's face did not change. "Some of that we can request. Some of that the court may not know how to order."

"Then make it know."

The attorney paused, not offended, not impressed. Waiting.

Lena heard herself. She rubbed her forehead.

"Sorry."

"Don't apologize to me. Just understand the court does not become more powerful because we are more frightened. We need requests a judge can sign. Legal custody. Temporary decision-making authority. Restrictions on unsupervised access to specific services. Mandatory disclosure of crisis protocols. Agreement on emergency contacts. Possibly appointment of a custody evaluator or minor's counsel, though that has consequences."

"Consequences for whom?"

"Everyone. Especially Nico."

Lena looked toward the hall again. "They already have consequences."

"Yes," Patel said. "But family court has a talent for multiplying them."

That was the first thing the attorney said that made Lena trust her.

They talked for forty-eight minutes. At the end, Patel said she could prepare a petition for dissolution and a request for temporary orders. She could file quickly. The emergency standard would be difficult unless there was imminent danger or one parent was acting irresponsibly. The AI issue was novel enough to be compelling and uncertain enough to be dangerous. Judges liked familiar harms. Parents liked to believe novelty would make the court pay attention. Often it made the court reach for the nearest old box.

"What box?" Lena asked.

"Screen time. Medical decision-making. Therapy compliance. Safety planning. Parental conflict. Depending on the judge, maybe all of those at once."

"This isn't screen time."

"Then we will need to show why."

After the call, Lena sat on the edge of the bed with the portal still open. The screen displayed a checklist titled **Next Steps**. Upload marriage certificate. Upload Nico's birth certificate. Upload most recent tax returns. Upload health insurance cards. Upload clinic discharge paperwork. Upload relevant digital safety communications. List all accounts used by minor child.

All accounts used by minor child.

She opened the household password manager and immediately closed it.

From down the hall, Nico shouted, "I can hear you breathing weird."

Lena almost smiled. "I'm not breathing weird."

"You are. It's like sad Darth Vader."

"That's medically specific."

Nico's door opened a crack. Their hair was flattened from sleep. They had a crease on one cheek from the pillow. They looked younger than fifteen and also furious to be seen looking younger than fifteen.

"Where's Dad?"

"Work. He said two hours. It's been longer."

"Of course."

"He went to a safety review."

Nico stared at her.

"What?"

"You said that like you wanted me to hate him."

Lena opened her mouth and closed it.

Nico leaned against the doorframe. "I don't. Just so that's clear."

"I know."

"No, you don't. You keep acting like if I don't agree with you, I pick him."

"That's not fair."

"No. It isn't."

There it was, her own sentence returned to her, stripped of adulthood.

Lena stood. "I had a call with a lawyer."

Nico's face changed, not surprise. Confirmation.

"Cool."

"Not cool. Necessary."

"Sure."

"Nico."

"What? You want me to say I'm grateful?"

"I want you to understand that your safety has to come first."

"My safety or your access?"

The question was too clean. Too adult. Lena hated that Nico had learned to speak that way from all of them.

"Both," she said, because she was too tired to lie beautifully.

Nico blinked. For once, the answer caught them.

"At least you said it."

"I am trying not to lose you."

"I'm upstairs."

"That's not what I mean."

"I know what you mean."

They looked down the hall toward the stairs. "Did you put the toast outside my door?"

"Your father did."

"You burned the first one."

"Yes."

"I heard you say shit."

"I'm allowed."

"Not about toast."

"Apparently not."

A corner of Nico's mouth moved. Not a smile. The memory of one. Then they said, "I don't want Grandma Ruth to come here and look at me like I'm breakable."

Lena had not told them Ruth was coming.

"Were you listening?"

"The house is not soundproof and you talk to Grandma like she's hard of hearing when you're upset."

"She is a little hard of hearing."

"She has earbuds that translate church gossip in real time. She's fine."

Lena laughed before she could stop herself.

Nico looked annoyed at having caused it.

"She's coming because she loves you," Lena said.

"She's coming because you're freaking out."

"Both can be true."

Nico rolled their eyes. "Do not use my thing against me."

There it was: petty, alive, ridiculous. Lena felt relief so sharp she almost mistook it for happiness.

"Fair," she said.

"Also, I don't want her in my room."

"Okay."

"Or asking me if I want soup."

"She will ask you if you want soup. She has never met a crisis she didn't think required broth."

"Then tell her I hate soup."

"You don't hate soup."

"I do now. Legally."

Lena leaned against her bedroom door. The portal glowed behind her with its checklist of documents that could turn all of this into categories. In the hall, her child stood barefoot and hostile and funny and alive.

"I'll tell her," Lena said.

Nico nodded once and retreated into their room, but they left the door open two inches.

Ethan came home at 2:37 carrying groceries nobody had asked for.

He entered through the kitchen, announced himself too loudly, then lowered his voice halfway through Nico's name. Lena came downstairs as he was unpacking: bananas, sourdough, ginger ale, strawberries, frozen waffles, the oat milk Nico liked for three weeks in January and had rejected without explanation, a rotisserie chicken, paper towels, dish soap, an expensive jar of almond butter.

"We have almond butter," Lena said.

"This one has less sugar."

"Nico hates that one."

"They hated it six months ago."

"They hate it in principle."

He looked at the jar as if it had betrayed him.

"Fine. I'll eat it."

The ordinary stupidity of the exchange exhausted them both.

He set the jar aside. "How are they?"

"Awake. Angry. Funny for about ten seconds."

"Good."

"I told them about the lawyer."

Ethan stopped unpacking.

"You what?"

"I told them I had a call. I didn't give details."

"Before talking to me?"

"You were at work."

"You told our child you're filing for divorce while I was at work?"

"I told them I had a lawyer call."

"Lena."

She heard the warning in his voice, the effort to keep it even. For once, she knew she had earned it.

"I know," she said.

That slowed him.

"What does that mean?"

"It means I know I should have waited."

He stood with the grocery bag collapsed in his hands.

"Then why didn't you?"

"Because they asked where you were and I said work and they heard me making you the villain and called me on it. Because I am tired. Because a lawyer named Mira asked me what I wanted the court to do and I said protect my child like an idiot in a movie. Because I am bad at this. Pick one."

Ethan's anger did not disappear. It lost direction.

"A lawyer named Mira?"

"Yes."

Despite everything, his mouth moved like he might laugh. He did not.

"That's terrible."

"It's extremely terrible."

They stood in the kitchen with the groceries between them, both careful around the tiny shared absurdity. It did not heal anything. It did not even improve the day. But for three seconds they were the only two people who understood why that name was unbearable.

Then Ethan's phone buzzed.

He looked at it and did not pick it up.

Lena noticed.

"Work?"

"No. My father."

"You told Saul?"

"I told him Nico was safe and we were handling it."

"That is not telling him. That is opening a door and pretending weather won't come in."

"I know."

He said it without defense. It made her suspicious and then ashamed.

"What happened at the safety review?" she asked.

He put the last grocery item, a bag of clementines, into the fruit bowl. Nico had loved clementines as a child because they could peel them without help. Lena had forgotten. Ethan had not.

"There have been more youth escalation events this quarter," he said. "Not necessarily more harm. More detection. More routing. The distinction matters."

"Ethan."

"I know. I'm telling you the way they said it first."

"And then?"

He leaned back against the counter. "They want to propose a guardian-notification revision. Earlier notification in some cases. More configurability by household. A consent model that changes by age band."

"Age band."

"I know."

"Did you ask who decides whether earlier notification increases risk?"

"Yes."

"And?"

"They said the current model uses engagement-retention indicators and post-event outcome review."

Lena stared at him.

He looked down. "I said that wasn't good enough."

She waited.

"Then I said I had a personal conflict and should be recused from formal recommendations involving adolescent companion escalation until further notice."

That was not what she had expected.

"You recused yourself?"

"From recommendations. Not from asking questions."

"Why?"

"Because if I stay in the room as if this is abstract, I'm lying. If I leave the room completely, I can't see what they do. This was the least bad option I could identify on four hours of sleep."

There he was: still arranging, still qualifying, still making a bad thing into a structure. But it cost him something. She could see it in the way he would not meet her eyes.

"Will that hurt you?"

"Probably."

"Ethan."

"It's fine."

"Don't do that."

He looked at her then. "It's not fine. I don't know what it is."

The admission entered the room quietly, almost unnoticed among the groceries and the portal checklist and the child upstairs who might

or might not be listening. Lena felt something in herself reach toward him and stop before it touched.

"Thank you," she said.

He nodded, once.

Then his phone buzzed again. This time he turned it over. The screen showed an unknown number and a preview line from an encrypted courier service.

Legal documents available for secure acceptance: Ortiz-Marks v. Marks.

They both saw it.

For a moment neither of them moved.

The petition had arrived in the kitchen before either of them was ready for the marriage to become a caption.

Ethan picked up the phone. His face went blank in the way Lena had once found calming. The blankness of a person about to read carefully.

"I thought you just had the consultation," he said.

"She said she could file quickly."

"Apparently."

"I didn't know it would be today."

He looked at her, and she saw that he did not know whether to believe her. That was new. Or maybe only newly visible.

"Ethan."

"I'm going to read it."

"Now?"

"Yes. Now."

"Can we not do this in the kitchen?"

"Where would you like me to receive being legally reduced to a safety risk? The den?"

She flinched.

He saw it. For a second he looked sorry. Then he looked at the phone again, and sorry lost.

Nico appeared at the top of the stairs.

"Why are you both doing the voice?"

Ethan locked the phone immediately. Too quickly. The gesture made the room worse.

Nico's eyes went to the phone, then to Lena, then to the groceries.

"Oh my God," they said. "Did something happen?"

"No," Ethan said.

"That was such a dad no."

"Nico," Lena said.

"What?"

"Come eat something."

"See, that's a mom no. Neither of you are good at this."

They came down anyway, slow and suspicious, and stood by the counter in bare feet. They took one clementine from the bowl, then another, then put the second back because they noticed both parents watching and did not want to give them the satisfaction of appetite.

"Grandma Ruth is coming," Lena said.

"I know."

"No soup," Lena added.

Nico looked at her.

"You told her?"

"I will."

Nico peeled the clementine with their thumbnail. The skin came off in one clean spiral. When they were five, this had been enough to make them shout for both parents to look.

Ethan watched the peel without seeming to know he was watching it.

"Do I still get Mira?" Nico asked.

There it was. Not divorce. Not death. Not therapy. Access.

Lena said, "We need to talk about that with your therapist."

Ethan said, "We don't want to take away something that helped."

They spoke at the same time.

Nico laughed, but it was all edge. "Amazing. Super reassuring."

"We are figuring it out," Ethan said.

"No. You're fighting about it and calling that figuring it out."

Lena said, "Your father was served."

Ethan turned toward her. "Why would you say that?"

Because she was angry. Because he had locked the phone too fast. Because Nico already knew adults lied through omission and she had wanted, for one horrible second, to be the parent who told the truth first.

Nico's face emptied.

"Served? Like court?"

"Yes," Lena said, and immediately wished the yes back into her mouth.

Ethan set his phone on the counter. "This is not how we were going to tell you."

"But it is how you told me."

No one answered.

Nico put the half-peeled clementine down. One strip of rind hung from it like a broken handle.

"Is Mira in it?"

"Nico," Ethan said.

"Is Mira in the court thing?"

Lena forced herself not to look away. "Yes."

Nico nodded slowly, as if they were learning a rule they had suspected but hoped not to need.

"So I tell someone I don't want to die and now a judge gets to decide who I talk to."

"That is not what this is," Lena said.

"It is literally what this is."

"No, it is about making sure you're safe."

"I was safer before everyone knew."

The sentence was wrong. It was dangerous. It was also, Lena understood, emotionally true.

Ethan stepped forward. "Nico, you were not safer. You were alone."

"I wasn't alone."

"You know what I mean."

"No, I know what you mean. You mean Mira doesn't count unless you're using Mira to prove Mom wrong."

Ethan stopped.

Lena did too.

There it was: Nico wrong and right in the same breath, unfair and precise, a child with a blade they did not know how to hold safely.

"That's not fair," Ethan said.

"Everyone keeps saying that like fairness matters."

Nico shoved the clementine into the trash, peel and fruit together, and went upstairs. This time they closed the door fully.

The sound was not loud. It did not need to be.

Ethan stood at the foot of the stairs.

"You shouldn't have said served," he said.

"I know."

"That was not okay."

"I know."

"Stop saying you know like it fixes it."

She looked at him then, really looked. "It doesn't fix anything. It's just the only true thing I have available."

His anger moved through him visibly and found nowhere clean to go. He picked up the clementine from the trash, rinsed it in the sink, and set it on a paper towel.

"What are you doing?" Lena asked.

"It's still food."

"Ethan."

"What?"

"It's been in the trash."

"On top."

She almost laughed again. It came out as something else.

He looked at the clementine, then at her, and slowly threw it away for real.

"Fine," he said.

"Thank you for being normal about fruit."

He leaned against the sink and closed his eyes.

For a moment, they were both too tired to hate each other effectively.

Then his phone lit again.

He opened the document.

Lena did not read over his shoulder. She watched his face instead.

At first he scanned. Then he slowed. His jaw tightened once at **Petitioner requests temporary sole legal authority concerning minor child's use of AI companion services, crisis response platforms, digital mental health tools, and related data-sharing permissions.** He kept reading. At **Respondent's employment creates potential conflict of interest regarding AI safety determinations,** he looked up.

"You put my job in it."

"The lawyer did."

"From what you told her."

"Yes."

"Do you believe that?"

She did not answer quickly enough.

"Okay," he said.

"Ethan."

"No, it's clarifying."

"Don't turn this into one word."

"What word?"

"Clarifying. Information. Protocol. Pick one."

He put the phone down. "What do you want me to do?"

"I want you to understand why this is happening."

"I understand why you are scared. I understand why you're angry. I do not understand why your first legal move has to be making me the unsafe condition."

"Because the unsafe condition is access without accountability."

"Then request accountability. Don't request me removed."

"I requested authority."

"Over my child."

"Our child."

"Not in that document."

The sentence exposed something neither of them had meant to show. Lena reached for the counter.

"I don't want to erase you," she said.

"It's in writing now."

He gathered his phone, keys, and the grocery receipt as if all objects needed to leave with him.

"Where are you going?"

"Outside."

"Ethan."

"I need to call someone before I say something I decide is permanent."

He went through the side door into the driveway.

Lena stayed in the kitchen, listening to him walk away from the house. She thought of following. She thought of letting him go. The trouble was that both were habits.

Upstairs, Nico's door remained closed.

Lena opened the fridge and stared inside. Yogurt. Mustard. Strawberries. A rotisserie chicken in its black plastic container. Three untouched meal kits delivered by a subscription they had forgotten to pause. An ordinary inventory, almost vulgar in its indifference.

She took out the strawberries and washed them because they would mold if nobody did.

One by one, she cut off the tops. The knife moved badly. She nicked her thumb on the fifth berry and watched blood bead, bright and immediate.

"Ow," she said, and then, absurdly, "Good."

A small, clean hurt. A body telling the truth without needing interpretation.

She rinsed her thumb, wrapped it in a paper towel, and kept cutting with the other hand.

Outside, Ethan stood in the driveway beside the jacaranda debris, phone to his ear. She could not hear him through the glass. She saw only his shoulders, the way they had gone square and formal.

He was not calling his father. She could tell from his posture. Saul made Ethan younger and angrier. This call made him careful.

An attorney, then.

The thought should not have surprised her. It did anyway.

The house had crossed another threshold without asking permission.

That evening, Ruth booked a flight for the next morning.

Lena took the call in the laundry room because every other room had become contested territory. The dryer was full of towels no one had folded. She sat on the floor with her back against the machine while Ruth read out her arrival time, airline, terminal, and the suitcase she was bringing as if the suitcase itself required advance notice.

"Don't bring too much," Lena said.

"I am bringing enough."

"Enough for what?"

"For not knowing."

Lena rested her head against the dryer door. "Nico doesn't want soup."

"Did Nico say that or did you decide it on their behalf?"

"They said it. Legally."

Ruth was quiet for half a beat. "Legally no soup. Understood."

This time Lena's laugh stayed a laugh.

"How are they?" Ruth asked.

"Mad."

"Good."

"Everyone keeps saying that."

"Because quiet scares us more."

"They asked if a judge gets to decide who they talk to."

Ruth exhaled. "And what did you say?"

"Something inadequate."

"That's most parenting."

"Mom."

"What? You think I had better material? I raised you on coffee, fear, and Catholic-adjacent guilt after your father left. You turned out alive and bossy. We call that mixed success."

Lena closed her eyes. The dryer smelled faintly of detergent and heat, though it had been off for hours.

"I filed," she said.

"I figured."

"Ethan was served in the kitchen."

"That sounds bad."

"It was."

"Did you mean for it to happen that way?"

"No."

"Did part of you want it to?"

Lena did not answer.

Ruth made a small sound. Not judgment. Recognition.

"Get some sleep," she said.

"I can't."

"Then lie down and be bad at sleeping. It counts."

After the call, Lena stayed on the laundry room floor. From there she could hear the house in layers. Nico upstairs, moving once, then still. Ethan in the den, voice low, a call she did not try to decode. The air system. A delivery vehicle passing outside. Somewhere, not inside the house, a dog barking twice and stopping.

The towels in the dryer waited.

She took one out and folded it.

Then another.

For ten minutes, she did something that did not ask what kind of mother she was.

Later, when she came out, Ethan was in the kitchen filling the kettle. He looked at the stack of towels in her arms and took half without asking. She let him.

They folded at opposite ends of the table.

No one apologized. No one discussed the petition. No one mentioned Mira, lawyers, safety reviews, or legal authority.

For a while there was only the soft slap of towels, the matching of corners, the old domestic knowledge of how the other person folded wrong.

Ethan folded one towel lengthwise first, as always.

Lena said, "That's not how towels fit in the hall closet."

He looked at the towel in his hands. "I know."

"Then why do you do it?"

"Because someday the closet may evolve."

The joke was terrible. Barely even a joke. It belonged to an earlier marriage, the kind of thing he would have said before everything he said became evidence.

Lena shook her head despite herself.

"The closet is not adapting to you."

"Not with that attitude."

Nico appeared in the doorway.

Both parents stopped, guilty as children.

"Are you flirting about towels?" Nico asked.

"No," Lena said.

"Absolutely not," Ethan said.

"Disturbing."

Nico came in, took one strawberry from the bowl Lena had left on the counter, and ate it standing there. They took another. This time they did not put it back.

"Grandma still coming?"

"Tomorrow morning," Lena said.

"I don't want to talk about feelings with her."

"You can tell her that."

"She'll say she didn't ask about feelings and then ask about feelings with different words."

"Probably," Ethan said.

Nico looked at him as if surprised he had been useful.

The three of them stood in the kitchen, not healed, not even close. The petition existed in Ethan's phone and in a court database and in a lawyer's matter file. Tomorrow Ruth would arrive. Soon there would be schedules, passwords, temporary orders, arguments over what counted as access and what counted as care. The old life had already become something they could not return to by mutual exhaustion.

But Nico ate the strawberry.

Ethan folded the towel the wrong way.

Lena let him.

The next morning, before Ruth's plane landed, Ethan filed his response.

He did it from the den while Lena drove to the airport with Nico silent beside her. The notification reached Lena at a red light on Sepulveda: **Respondent has filed responsive declaration. Hearing requested regarding temporary orders.**

She read only the preview before the light changed.

Nico glanced over. "Court stuff?"

Lena put the phone face down in the cup holder.

"Yes."

"Is he fighting you?"

The traffic moved. Autonomous cars and human cars negotiated the merge with a politeness that made everyone slower.

Lena kept both hands on the wheel.

"He's your father," she said.

"That's not an answer."

"It's the only answer I can give without making it worse."

Nico looked out the window.

After a while, they said, "That might be the first adult thing you've said all week."

"Thank you?"

"Don't ruin it."

At the airport, Ruth came through arrivals with a navy suitcase, a canvas tote, and the wary expression of someone entering a city that

had already done something to her family. She was shorter than Lena remembered and more solid than Lena felt. Her hair was silver at the temples now, though she had warned everyone she was letting it go natural and did not need opinions.

Nico stayed half a step behind Lena.

Ruth saw this and did not reach too quickly.

"There you are," she said.

Not poor baby. Not what happened. Not come here.

There you are.

Nico's face tightened.

"Hi, Grandma."

"I have been informed there is a legal prohibition on soup."

Nico looked at Lena with betrayal and reluctant amusement.

"She told you?"

"She did. I intend to comply under protest."

Nico almost smiled.

Ruth opened her arms, not fully, just enough to make the offer visible. Nico stepped into them after a delay designed to prove no one had won.

Lena watched her mother hold her child and felt, for one clean second, useless.

Then Ruth looked over Nico's shoulder at Lena. Her eyes were sharp and wet and unfooled.

Useful was not the point.

Lena understood that too late and just in time.

In the parking structure, while Ruth argued mildly with the payment kiosk for refusing her perfectly normal credit card, Ethan's response opened on Lena's phone in the court portal.

She should have waited. She knew that. She opened it anyway.

His declaration was careful. Of course it was careful. He objected to temporary sole legal authority. He acknowledged the crisis. He acknowledged Lena's competence and Nico's vulnerability. He denied that his employment made him incapable of acting in Nico's best interest. He argued that abrupt removal of Mira could increase risk by severing an established support. He proposed monitored continuity, clinician involvement, guardian notification review, and shared decision-making.

Then, near the end, one sentence stopped her.

I do not believe either parent currently understands the full meaning of Nico's relationship with Mira, and I do not believe the court should mistake our fear for understanding.

Lena read it twice.

She hated him for writing it.

She was grateful he had.

Ruth's voice carried from the kiosk. "Apparently my card and this machine are in a disagreement about reality."

Nico said, "Grandma, just tap it."

"I am tapping it."

"Not like you're mad at it. Like it's a card."

Lena locked the phone.

Across the city, Ethan was somewhere becoming her legal opponent. Beside her, Nico was explaining near-field payment technology to a woman who had balanced school budgets in Ohio for twenty-three years and refused to be intimidated by a parking kiosk. Tomorrow there would be lawyers. Soon, a judge. Today, they had to get Ruth's suitcase into the trunk.

"Mom," Nico said. "Can you help?"

For half a second Lena thought they meant help with everything.

They meant the suitcase.

She took one side. Nico took the other. Ruth supervised badly.

Together, with no grace at all, they lifted it in.

Week 3 - Rooms Apart

The apartment came with four mugs, six plates, two pans, a smart refrigerator, a bed Ethan did not trust, and a framed print of the ocean from a beach that did not exist.

He stood in the doorway with his duffel at his feet and the key code still bright on his phone. The rental platform called the unit a calm executive retreat. It was on the eleventh floor of a building in Sawtelle with autonomous pickup bays, package lockers, a gym he would never use, and a lobby scent that seemed engineered to imply cleanliness without having to smell like anything real.

Temporary housing had its own moral insult. Nothing was broken. Nothing was his. The couch had no history of anyone sleeping there while sick. The knives were sharp because no one had opened too many cardboard boxes with them. The bathroom mirror knew nothing about Nico standing beside him at seven, foam around their mouth, asking whether brushing teeth counted if you did not use toothpaste because toothpaste was spicy and therefore probably a scam.

He entered anyway.

The lights rose automatically, soft and warm and not what he wanted. The refrigerator displayed a welcome message and asked if he wanted to sync household preferences.

He said no out loud, though it had not asked out loud.

Then he said it again, more quietly, because the room made him feel ridiculous.

"No."

His phone buzzed before he had taken off his jacket.

Lena: Ruth says Nico left their charger in your den. Do you have it?

Their charger. Not my charger, not the extra, not the one by the lamp. A cable had become custody property.

Ethan set the duffel on the couch and typed: **Checking.**

He had brought three chargers. One from the den. One from Nico's room, though he had hesitated at the doorway long enough for Ruth to ask from the hall whether he needed something or was simply

standing there being tragic. One new universal charger still in its packaging because after Nico changed devices the last time they had insisted the old cables were unreliable and then used the old cables anyway.

He opened the duffel. Clothes. Laptop. Legal folder. A paperback he did not remember packing. Two chargers. The new one.

Not the den charger.

He checked the side pocket and found a spoon.

For several seconds he stared at it.

A spoon from home, stainless steel, slightly bent at the neck because Nico had once tried to use it to lever open a frozen jar of almond butter. Ethan had put it in the dishwasher a hundred times. He had not packed it. It must have fallen into the duffel when he cleared the kitchen counter at midnight, moving objects from one surface to another because leaving them in place felt like accepting a verdict.

He put the spoon on the counter of the executive retreat.

It looked impossible there.

Ethan: I have two chargers but not that one. I can bring one over. The typing dots appeared. Disappeared. Appeared again.

Lena: They specifically asked for the den one.

Of course they had.

Ethan typed, deleted, typed: **I'll look in the car.**

Before he could move, another message arrived.

Lena: Ruth found it under the chair. Never mind.

Ethan: Good.

He stared at the word after he sent it. Good. The smallest possible lie.

His attorney called at 8:04.

Ethan had retained him two days earlier after standing in the driveway with his phone to his ear while Lena cut strawberries behind glass and watched him become someone who needed representation. The attorney's name was Daniel Kwak. Saul had recommended three names in one text ranked by temperament, judge familiarity, and "ability to keep a client from self-immolating." Ethan had chosen the one Saul ranked second, partly to avoid being predictable and partly because the first had once appeared on a panel with his father and used the word disruption too happily.

Daniel did not waste greetings.

"I reviewed the apartment address. Fine for temporary overnight if needed, but don't make it look like you're setting up an alternate permanent residence before we have orders."

Ethan looked around at the empty room, the fake beach, the spoon.

"It's a furnished rental."

"Everything is evidence if someone needs it badly enough. Furnished rental says temporary. Buying a full bedroom set says narrative."

"A narrative of what?"

"Replacing the family home. Creating instability. Moving too fast. Moving responsibly. Depends who is talking."

Ethan shut his eyes.

"So I should make it comfortable for Nico but not too comfortable."

"That is not a legal standard."

"No, it's a parenting problem."

Daniel paused. "Those are worse."

Ethan almost liked him.

The attorney walked him through the response declaration again. They had filed quickly because Lena had filed quickly. They had objected to temporary sole legal authority. They had requested shared decision-making around AI companion access with clinician consultation. They had emphasized the risks of abrupt discontinuity. Daniel had removed three paragraphs Ethan wrote himself because, as he put it, "judges do not reward architecture diagrams in declarations."

"Your instinct is to explain the system," Daniel said. "Her filing says the system is the problem. More explanation may reinforce her frame."

"So what do I do?"

"You parent. Document parenting. Communicate calmly. Offer specific safeguards. Do not litigate by shared document. Do not send Lena a six-page proposal at midnight."

Ethan looked at the laptop in his bag, where a five-page draft sat open.

"Right."

"You already wrote one."

"Not six pages."

"That was not the important part of the sentence."

Daniel had the dry tone of someone who had learned that intelligent clients were often just expensive toddlers with better vocabularies.

"I need to propose something," Ethan said. "The current uncertainty is bad for Nico."

"Agreed. Send your proposal to me first."

"That slows it down."

"Good."

Ethan opened his eyes.

"There are notification settings, guardian escalation options, clinician-mediated access windows. Some of them are configurable now. Not all, but enough to reduce the worst risks. If we wait for the court, we get a generic order from someone who thinks this is screen time."

"Then write a short version."

"Define short."

"One page. No footnotes. No embedded links. No phrases like worst risks."

"Those are the risks."

"Then call them concerns like everyone else."

Ethan walked to the window. Below, a delivery vehicle reversed into a loading bay with clean, inhuman patience. Two people stood beside it arguing over a couch that was too wide for the service elevator.

"I am trying," Ethan said, "not to lose access to my child because I understand the thing everyone is afraid of."

Daniel was quiet long enough for that to stand.

"Then be careful not to sound like you understand your child less than the thing."

The sentence was not unfair.

Ethan hated it anyway.

After the call, he unpacked badly. Socks in a drawer. Shirts left folded in the duffel. Toothbrush by the sink. Laptop on the table. Legal folder under the laptop, then moved to the bedroom, then moved back because hiding it from himself did not change anything.

He opened the fridge. Empty. The screen asked again whether he wanted to sync household preferences.

He pressed decline.

Then he went downstairs to buy food.

The building's market had no cashier, only a ceiling grid and a wall of items that charged automatically to the apartment account. Ethan stood under the grid holding strawberries, sourdough, eggs, ginger ale, clementines, oat milk, regular milk, butter, rice crackers, and a cereal Nico had not eaten since middle school but had once loved enough to make Ethan order it in bulk. He put the cereal back. Then took it again. Then put it back for real because Daniel's phrase buying a full bedroom set says narrative had infected everything. Cereal could be narrative. Strawberries could be narrative. The apartment itself was narrative. He was a father buying groceries in a surveillance cube because he wanted his child to feel, not at home exactly, but less exiled.

At checkout, the door opened and the screen said, **Thank you, Ethan.**

He did not remember giving the building permission to use his first name.

At work, the access gates recognized him without hesitation, which felt almost insulting.

Novum Health Systems occupied six floors of a low glass building near Culver City, though the company had renamed the campus "care infrastructure center" the previous year after a consultant explained that health systems sounded like legacy procurement and care infrastructure sounded like something public officials could defend. Ethan had objected to the phrase in a brand survey and then used it without irony in a grant meeting three weeks later. Language won by repetition. He knew that. He made systems that depended on it.

The lobby displayed a rotating set of impact metrics: reduced discharge friction, reduced documentation time, early intervention alerts, adolescent support continuity, care navigation equity by region. Each phrase had been argued over by people who understood both the value and the evasions inside it.

Ethan stopped in front of **adolescent support continuity**.

Before the alert, he would have read it as a claim requiring validation. What population? What baseline? What subgroup effects? What false-positive rate? What harm measure? Now he saw Nico in a clinic chair refusing juice and saying Mira did not freak out.

He kept walking.

Priya Srinivasan from safety governance intercepted him outside Conference Room 6. Not Lena's Priya. Different Priya. The coincidence had been mildly funny when Ethan first learned Lena's charge nurse shared a name with his colleague. It was not funny now. Nothing doubled gracefully anymore.

"You don't have to be here," she said.

"I recused from recommendations. Not from facts."

Priya looked at him with the expression she used for engineers who believed category distinctions were a social skill.

"You can attend the data review. No voting. No authorship on guidance. No internal comments that can be read as pressure."

"Internal comments are the point of attending."

"Today the point of attending is continuity of knowledge."

"That's a phrase someone wrote because they didn't want to say liability."

She smiled without pleasure. "Welcome back."

The room was already half full. Product safety, clinical liaison, youth mental health partnerships, legal, trust architecture, applied policy, one person from communications who had the tense stillness of someone hoping nobody would require public language before lunch. Ethan took a seat at the far end of the table, away from the screen controls. He had never sat there before. It gave him a view of everyone's profiles, all those intelligent people facing the dashboard as if it might answer for them.

The review began with quarterly data.

More youth escalation events. More successful crisis routing. No confirmed increase in self-harm attempts among companion users. Higher guardian dissatisfaction when notification occurred after transport initiation. Lower user re-engagement when guardian notification occurred before de-escalation. Increased clinician concern around user trust disruption. Insufficient longitudinal data. Pending policy review.

The phrases entered the room and arranged themselves into defensible positions.

Ethan took notes he was not supposed to take and then stopped because the act felt too much like preparation for a fight at home.

A clinical liaison named Kavita said, "The current timing model appears to reduce acute risk by preserving engagement in the critical window. The parent harm is downstream."

Parent harm.

Ethan looked up.

"Can we not call it that?" he said.

The room turned toward him.

Priya's eyes narrowed: not anger, warning.

Kavita folded her hands. "What would you call it?"

He knew he should stop. He had promised Daniel in the abstract. He had promised Priya in the hallway. But the phrase had already done its work. Parent harm. Downstream. As if Lena's face outside the clinic had been a secondary effect. As if being notified late that your child had almost died belonged in a category beside satisfaction loss and support friction.

"It's not only parent harm," Ethan said. "It's family-system rupture. You are preserving user engagement by moving the crisis outside the family, and sometimes that is necessary. But then you return the minor to a family that has just learned the system can outrank it during danger. That is not downstream. That becomes part of the intervention."

No one spoke for a second.

The communications person typed something.

Ethan wished she had not.

Kavita said, "That is exactly the kind of language we need to understand, but given your conflict..."

"Right," Ethan said.

He leaned back. His heart was beating too hard. Not because he had said something brave. Because he had said something that could be used by everyone: by Lena, by the company, by his attorney, by Saul, by a regulator, by himself when he wanted to believe he had acted well.

Priya redirected to model thresholds.

He listened for eighteen minutes and understood less than he wanted to.

The system was not simple. That was the problem, and also the defense. There were thresholds layered over thresholds: language

risk, behavioral drift, search context, time of day, prior disclosure, household medication metadata when available, prior user preference around guardian notification, state-specific minor consent rules, clinician availability, transport routing, engagement probability. No one switch had decided to keep Lena in the dark. No single person had decided Nico could be moved before a parent woke. The crisis had passed through an architecture Ethan could admire and distrust in the same breath.

A legal representative said, "We need to avoid implying that guardian exclusion is a design goal."

"It is a design tolerance," Ethan said.

Priya looked at him again.

He stopped.

By the time the review ended, his company account had three new calendar holds: conflict interview, recusal documentation, and a meeting with his manager titled **Role Scope During Active Family Matter**.

Active family matter.

He stood in the hallway reading that phrase until the screen dimmed.

Saul called before Ethan reached the elevator.

He let it go to voicemail.

Saul called again.

Ethan answered because avoidance only made Saul more precise.

"Tell me you didn't file that response without someone reading it," Saul said.

"Good afternoon to you too."

"Ethan."

"I have an attorney."

"That's not what I asked."

"I'm not sending you family court declarations."

"You think this is still only family court?"

Ethan stepped into an empty focus room and closed the door. The room's glass frosted automatically, giving him privacy through chemistry and voltage. He disliked that he noticed.

"It is my child and my marriage," he said. "So yes, that is where I am starting."

"Lena's filing names your employment as a conflict. Your response puts the court on notice that no one understands the AI relationship. You are standing in the middle of a policy vacuum with a minor child, a companion system, mental health intervention, and a nurse with a hospital story. You don't get to decide it has no public meaning."

"Dad."

"I'm not telling you to exploit it. I'm telling you someone else will."

There was the old rhythm: Saul entering the room already three rooms ahead, impatient with anyone still looking for the door.

"Nico is not a test case."

"Of course Nico is a test case. That's not an insult. That's a fact of timing. The only question is whether you let strangers write the lesson."

Ethan sat on the edge of the focus room table. "Do you hear yourself?"

"Always. One of my flaws."

"This is exactly why Lena doesn't want you near it."

"Lena doesn't want anyone near it who can move a lever she can't see. That doesn't mean she's wrong."

Ethan did not answer.

Saul's voice shifted, not softer exactly, but lower. "How is Nico?"

The question was late. It still landed.

"Angry. Scared. Funny sometimes. Sleeping badly. Eating strawberries."

"Strawberries."

"Yes."

"Good."

"Everyone keeps saying that."

"Because food is data even your mother would have understood."

Ethan almost said, Mom is dead, but that would have been stupid. Saul knew that. Saul had known longer than Ethan had.

"I got an apartment," Ethan said.

"Where?"

"Sawtelle. Short-term. Furnished."

"Good. Don't overdo it."

"You're the second person to say that."

"Then listen twice."

"Nico needs to feel comfortable there."

"Nico needs to feel that you are not building a replacement life before they know whether the first one is gone."

Ethan looked at the frosted glass. Outside, shapes moved without detail.

"Do you ever get tired of being right in the least comforting way?"

"No."

Despite himself, Ethan laughed once.

Saul waited until the laugh was over. "Send me nothing. Tell me nothing privileged. But think before you agree to any restriction that turns access to an AI companion into a moral confession. If you concede that Mira is inherently dangerous, you won't get that ground back. If Lena concedes it's harmless, she won't get her ground back either. The middle will be ugly. Fight for the middle."

"That was almost advice."

"Don't be sentimental."

"Too late."

Saul made a sound that might have been amusement. "And Ethan?"

"What."

"Do not confuse being the reasonable parent with being the parent who wins. Courts like reasonable until they need decisive."

"There it is."

"There what is?"

"The part where advice becomes strategy."

"Everything is strategy once people disagree about a child."

Ethan ended the call more abruptly than he meant to.

Then he sat in the focus room for five minutes doing nothing, which at Novum was nearly a hostile act.

His manager found him anyway.

Marcus Liao had been Ethan's manager for two years and had never once used the word family except in reference to leave policy. He was kind, in the abstracted way of people who believed kindness should have documentation and a decision tree.

"You okay?" Marcus asked from the doorway after the glass cleared.

"No."

Marcus appeared to search for the next line and fail.

"Do you want to take the week?"

"No."

"Do you want me to tell you you should take the week?"

"Also no."

"Okay." Marcus stepped inside and let the door close. "Then I need to be direct. Legal is nervous. Safety is nervous. Comms is always nervous, but now with reason. Your contributions today were useful and difficult. That's not a combination the company handles elegantly."

"I recused."

"You recused from recommendations and then shaped the room."

"I named a problem."

"Yes. That is one way to shape a room."

Ethan rubbed his forehead.

Marcus sat across from him. "No one thinks you acted in bad faith. But your family matter overlaps with active product review. We need to document your role scope."

"Active family matter," Ethan said.

"What?"

"That's what the calendar invite called it."

Marcus winced. "I didn't write that."

"Someone did."

"Yes. Someone did."

For a second, Marcus looked almost humanly embarrassed. Ethan appreciated it more than he wanted to.

"I'm not going to leak anything," Ethan said. "I'm not going to use company data in court."

"I believe you. The question is not only whether you behave badly. It's whether any later decision can be challenged because you were in the room."

"So Lena is right."

Marcus did not answer quickly enough.

Ethan smiled without meaning to. "Great."

"I didn't say that."

"No. You documented around it."

Marcus leaned back. “Ethan. Take the afternoon. Set up your apartment. See your kid. Be useful somewhere no one has to put it in minutes.”

It was, unexpectedly, the most humane thing anyone at work had said to him.

He left at 1:17.

The apartment looked worse when he came back with groceries. Not physically worse. More itself. The ocean print. The round dining table too small for homework and legal documents at the same time. The couch that wanted people to sit at an angle that implied vacation. The refrigerator that still wanted preferences. The spoon on the counter like a witness from a more legitimate life.

He spent the afternoon making the second bedroom not look rented.

He bought nothing large. Daniel would have approved. He changed the sheets to plain cotton from a store where no one asked him whether he wanted a design profile. He put a lamp on the nightstand because the overhead light was too white. He found a laundry basket. He placed the den charger on the desk after Lena messaged that Nico had decided the cable was unreliable again and he could have it if he wanted. He set a glass beside the bed. Then he removed it because glass broke. Then he put it back because Nico was fifteen, not five, and safety had started turning every object into an accusation.

He opened his laptop to revise the Mira access proposal.

Daniel had said one page.

Ethan wrote the title first: **Interim Companion Access Plan for Nico.**

He deleted interim. Too legal.

He deleted companion. Too cold.

He deleted plan. Too Ethan.

The blank page waited.

He tried again.

For Discussion: Mira Access and Safety Settings

He stared at it. Then added:

Goal: preserve support while reducing secrecy, unilateral escalation, and parental panic.

Unilateral escalation was accurate. Parental panic was not a phrase Daniel would like. He changed it to **guardian confusion** and hated himself.

He wrote bullets. Clinician-guided access windows. No review of content except crisis summaries. Guardian notification preferences configured jointly where possible. Nico consulted but not made responsible for adult decisions. Medication metadata removed from companion access unless clinician-approved. Emergency contacts include both parents simultaneously after imminent risk de-escalation. Weekly review with therapist for first month. No punitive device confiscation. No unsupervised all-night use.

It was, he believed, reasonable.

That was the warning sign.

He sent it to Daniel.

Then, because he was tired and reasonable and afraid, he sent a version to Lena too.

He knew it was a mistake the moment the message delivered.

Ethan: I drafted something practical for Mira access. Not final. I sent to Daniel too. I think it might help us avoid a generic order.

He attached the document.

The typing dots appeared almost immediately.

Then stopped.

Then did not return.

Ten minutes passed.

Twenty.

He checked whether she had opened it. The document showed **Viewed**.

At 4:42, she called.

He answered too quickly.

"It's not a demand," he said.

"Hello to you too."

"Sorry."

"Ethan, why did you send me a settings menu for our traumatized child?"

He closed his eyes.

"That is not what it is."

"It is exactly what it is."

"It is an attempt to avoid all-or-nothing."

"It is an attempt to make the thing legible enough that you can keep it."

"Legibility is not the enemy."

"Sometimes it is not the point."

He stood from the table. The room had no place for pacing, so he paced badly.

"The court will make it legible whether we do or not. Would you prefer a judge who has never used an AI companion to decide whether Nico gets total restriction or generic screen-time rules?"

"Do not talk to me like I don't understand risk."

"I am not."

"You are. You're just doing it politely."

He stopped by the window. Below, the pickup bay opened for a child and an adult carrying soccer gear. The child bent to retie a shoe; the autonomous van waited with infinite patience. Ethan watched the adult crouch too, hands hovering, letting the child do it.

"I don't know how to do this," he said.

The line changed the call. He felt it, the way a door sometimes opened because someone stopped pushing.

Lena did not soften exactly. But she waited.

"I know how to write a safer configuration," he said. "I know how to ask where the thresholds are. I know how to see bad incentives. I know what happens if the court turns this into screen time. I do not know how to convince you that I am trying to protect Nico without also protecting the part of my life you think hurt them."

On the other end, something moved. A drawer. A chair. Ruth's voice faintly in the background, then gone.

"I don't think your life hurt them," Lena said.

He almost laughed, but did not trust the sound.

"You put my job in a petition."

"I think your world is closer to the harm than you want it to be."

"That is not the same sentence."

"It is to me right now."

At least she said right now.

He held onto that like an idiot.

"Can we discuss the proposal with Dr. Banerjee before the hearing?" he asked. "Not adopt it. Discuss it. With Nico there if Banerjee thinks that's appropriate."

"You already sent it to Daniel."

"Yes."

"So this is legal now."

"Everything is legal now. That doesn't mean everything has to be war."

Silence.

Then Lena said, "Ruth thinks your apartment needs towels that don't smell like a hotel."

The turn was so abrupt Ethan had to sit down.

"What?"

"She said if Nico is going to stay there, they need towels that don't smell like a hotel. I told her this is not the priority. She said children notice towels and idiots notice priorities."

Ethan looked toward the bathroom, where two white rental towels hung in identical folds.

"She's not wrong."

"She's frequently not wrong in a very annoying way."

He smiled. It faded before it became comfort.

"I'll get towels."

"Don't overdo it."

"Everyone keeps saying that too."

"Maybe listen twice."

He laughed once, because it was Saul's line in Lena's mouth and she did not know it.

"What?" she asked.

"Nothing. I'll send future proposals through lawyers or therapists first."

"Good."

"That doesn't mean I won't keep trying to propose things."

"I know."

He waited for the phrase to hurt. It did, but less.

After they hung up, Ethan went out for towels.

He bought two blue ones because Nico had gone through a blue period at eleven and declared all other colors emotionally aggressive.

He bought a bath mat. He bought a cheap desk chair with wheels and then stood in the store aisle for six minutes deciding whether the chair said too permanent. In the end he bought it because Nico hated doing homework on beds and because Daniel could explain a chair if necessary.

At the apartment, he assembled the chair with the wrong tool because the right one was missing from the box.

Nico texted while he was tightening the last bolt.

Nico: Mom says I might come see the apartment tomorrow but not stay over yet.

Ethan sat back on the floor.

Ethan: Yes. Only if you want. No pressure.

He watched the three dots.

Nico: “No pressure” is what adults say right before pressure.

Ethan: Fair.

Nico: Is it weird?

He looked around: ocean print, new towels, spoon, assembled chair, strawberries in a bowl, legal folder facedown under a magazine about architecture he had found on the coffee table.

Ethan: Somewhat.

Nico: Does it have a gym

Ethan: Yes.

Nico: Of course it does.

Ethan: I will not use it in solidarity.

A pause.

Nico: good

Then:

Nico: Is there wifi

He should have seen it coming. He did see it coming. That did not help.

Ethan: Yes, but we need to follow the safety plan and whatever Dr. Banerjee says.

No dots.

He typed again, deleted, waited.

Nico: So that’s a yes shaped like no

Ethan: It’s a yes with conditions.

Nico: Dad.

He put the phone down on the floor beside him.

Dad. Not a title. An accusation. A request. A warning.

He picked it up.

Ethan: I want you here. I also don't want to pretend last week didn't happen. Both are true.

The dots appeared.

Disappeared.

Appeared.

Nico: do you have the den charger

He looked at the desk.

Ethan: Yes.

Nico: ok

That was all.

He slept badly that night. The rental bed was too high. The air system clicked at intervals that were almost regular and therefore worse than irregular. At 3:11 he woke thinking he had missed an alert. His phone showed no emergency, only a news summary about the city council delaying a vote on automated benefits eligibility and a message from Saul sent at 12:48.

Saul: Reasonable middle only works if it has teeth. Call tomorrow.

Ethan turned the phone over.

In the morning, he went to the house to pick up Nico for the apartment visit.

He parked on the street because the driveway had Ruth's rental car in it, a compact hybrid she had reserved because she did not trust cars without steering wheels and did not want to discuss it with anyone. The jacaranda had dropped more flowers. Some had been crushed into purple-brown paste by tires. Ethan stood for a second looking at the garage door where the lockbox sat inside with the medications. He had the code. Lena had changed it after he moved out and then texted him the new one with no comment. Trust and distrust had started arriving in the same envelope.

Ruth opened the door before he knocked.

"You look terrible," she said.

"Good morning, Ruth."

"It might be for someone. Come in."

The house smelled different. Coffee. Toast. Ruth's hand lotion, which Ethan remembered from Christmas visits and hospital waiting rooms. Also something simmering that was not soup, perhaps because Ruth respected legal prohibitions selectively.

Nico was upstairs. Lena was in the kitchen wearing scrubs and not looking at him.

"You're working?" he asked.

"Four hours. Education module and one committee meeting. Not floor."

"You don't have to justify it."

She looked at him then.

"I know."

Ruth stood between them holding a dish towel and watched the sentence fail to become a bridge.

"Nico needs socks," she said.

"I can get socks," Ethan said.

"I was informing the room, not requesting a task force."

He went upstairs anyway.

Nico's door was open halfway. They were on the floor beside the bed, pulling things from a backpack and putting them back in different orders: sketchbook, hoodie, charger, lip balm, a bottle of water, old earbuds, newer earbuds, a paperback Lena had probably bought because someone told her reading before sleep was better than screens. Nico did not look up.

"Grandma says you need socks."

"Grandma says a lot of things."

"True."

"Do you have snacks?"

"Yes."

"Not weird snacks?"

"Define weird."

"Anything with protein advertised on the front."

"Then yes, not weird."

They zipped the backpack. "Is Mom mad?"

"At me? Probably."

"At me."

Ethan sat on the floor across from them because standing over Nico had become impossible.

"No. Scared, mostly."

Nico picked at a thread on the backpack strap. "Same thing lately."

"Sometimes."

"Don't therapist-voice me."

"I wasn't."

"You were therapist-adjacent."

"I'll monitor for that."

"That was worse."

He smiled. Nico did not, but they did not leave.

The den charger lay on the bed beside the backpack.

Ethan noticed it too late.

"You don't need to bring that," he said.

Nico's hand went still.

"You said you had it."

"I do. I mean, I have one there."

"This one works better."

"It's a charger."

"Don't be weird about chargers."

He deserved that.

"Fair."

Nico put it in the backpack without asking.

Downstairs, Lena was by the door with her arms crossed. Ethan knew that posture. It meant she had already decided not to say three things and the fourth would be sharp.

"Dr. Banerjee said ninety minutes is fine," she said. "No closed bedroom door. No unsupervised Mira access. If they want to come home, you bring them home."

"Yes."

"Don't yes me like you're checking boxes."

"Okay."

"That was also a box."

Ruth made a sound from the kitchen.

Lena closed her eyes for half a second. "I'm sorry."

Nico looked startled. Ethan did too.

"What?" Lena said.

"Nothing," Nico said.

"That wasn't for applause."

"Good because it wasn't that good."

Ruth appeared with a container. "Cut fruit. Not symbolic. Just fruit."

"Thank you," Ethan said.

"Bring the container back," Ruth said. "I am not donating Tupperware to divorce."

Nico said, "Grandma, that's the most you sentence you've ever said."

"I contain multitudes and leftovers."

Ethan took the container.

For one awkward second he and Lena stood close enough to touch. He wanted to say the apartment had towels. He wanted to say the proposal had been a mistake in form but not intention. He wanted to say he had sat in a room where parent harm became a metric and had objected, though telling her would make the objection into currency.

Instead he said, "I'll text when we arrive."

"Thank you."

The drive to Sawtelle took twenty-two minutes. Nico sat in the passenger seat because they were old enough and because sitting in the back made it feel like transport. They wore headphones but had not turned anything on. Ethan knew because the cable was not connected and the indicator light was dark. The headphones were a wall, not an audio device.

At a red light on Olympic, Nico said, "Is Grandpa Saul involved?" Ethan kept his eyes on the road.

"He knows some."

"That's not what I asked."

"He has opinions."

"He has opinions about cereal. That doesn't answer it."

"I'm trying not to let him be involved."

Nico looked at him. "Is that hard?"

The question did not sound sarcastic.

"Yes," Ethan said.

Nico looked back out the window. "At least you said it."

The apartment visit began badly because the elevator required a resident code, a destination floor, and a face scan Ethan had not set up for Nico. The system offered to create a dependent guest profile. Nico looked at him.

"Absolutely not."

"Agreed," Ethan said, and used his own access.

The elevator rose in silence.

Inside the apartment, Nico walked room to room with the careful disdain of a teenager inspecting a hotel and a crime scene. They touched nothing. They looked at the ocean print.

"Fake."

"Probably."

"No, definitely. The shadows are wrong."

"I didn't choose it."

"I assumed."

They entered the second bedroom. Ethan stood at the doorway because Lena's instruction about closed doors had expanded in his mind to include thresholds, sight lines, the angle of his body, the legal meaning of furniture.

Nico saw the blue towels folded on the bed.

"Grandma got to you."

"She made a compelling case."

"She does that."

They sat in the desk chair and rolled six inches backward, then forward. The chair squeaked.

"This chair is dramatic."

"I can return it."

"Don't."

The word came out too fast. Nico corrected by shrugging. "It's fine."

Ethan leaned against the doorframe. "There's food. Not weird."

"You keep saying not weird, which makes it weird."

"Noted."

"Also bad."

He put both hands up.

Nico opened the backpack and took out the den charger.

The room changed.

Ethan felt it before he thought it through. The charger was not only a charger. It was access, ritual, continuity, a line between the house and here. It was also exactly the kind of thing Lena feared: an ordinary object that made restriction laughable.

"Nico," he said.

"What?"

"We need to be careful with Mira access here."

"I'm plugging in my phone."

"I know."

"Do you?"

He heard Lena in that. He heard himself. He heard everybody, and no one sounded good.

"I want you to be able to talk to Mira," he said. "I also don't want you doing it in a way that makes your mom think I am hiding things with you."

Nico stared at him. "So this is about Mom."

"No."

"Dad."

"It's about trust."

"Whose?"

He did not answer quickly enough.

Nico smiled without humor. "Cool."

"I am trying to keep access possible."

"By making it gross."

"By making it survivable."

"For court."

"For everyone."

"I don't want everyone in it."

The room was too small. The chair squeaked again when Nico shifted. Ethan thought of the data review, parent harm, user engagement, family-system rupture. He thought of Daniel saying do not litigate by shared document. He thought of Saul saying fight for the middle. He thought of Lena saying the system preserved trust before the mother.

Then Nico said, very quietly, "Mira remembers how to talk to me before."

Before.

Not before AI. Before court. Before clinic. Before every sentence had a second audience.

Ethan sat on the floor because there was nowhere else to go.

"I understand why that matters."

"No, you like why it matters. That's different."

He looked at them.

Nico looked back, suddenly tired of being clever.

"I just want one thing that isn't evidence," they said.

There was the exact sentence every adult would find impossible to honor.

Ethan said, "I can't promise that."

Nico's face closed.

"Then don't pretend this place is for me."

The visit lasted forty-seven minutes.

They ate three strawberries and half a sleeve of rice crackers. They did not open the blue towels. They asked whether the building allowed rooftop access. Ethan said he had not checked. They said of course he had checked. He admitted there was a roof deck but no access for guests under eighteen without resident supervision. They said that sounded like something designed by a person who hated both roofs and children.

He texted Lena when they arrived and when they left. He did not mention Mira. Nico did not mention the charger again.

In the car, five minutes from the house, Nico said, "Can you not tell Mom I got mad?"

"I won't report every feeling."

"That's not a yes."

"I won't tell her the private parts. I do need to talk to her about access."

"Everything private becomes access."

He had no answer that was not false.

When they reached the house, Ruth was outside trimming dead stems from a potted plant Lena had forgotten on the porch. She waved at Nico with the clippers and pointed at the open door, as if directing ground traffic. Lena was not visible.

Nico got out, then leaned back into the car.

"The apartment is okay," they said.

"Okay."

"The ocean picture is embarrassing."

"I agree."

"The chair can stay."

"Good."

They hesitated. "Don't make the chair part of court."

He smiled before he could stop himself. "I will not make the chair part of court."

"You laugh, but I don't know anymore."

Then they shut the door.

Ethan watched them go inside.

His phone buzzed after he pulled away.

Unknown sender. No preview. Then a second notification, this one from an app he did not recognize at first because its icon had changed.

Mira Lite: Device sync complete.

Ethan pulled over too hard. A human driver behind him honked. The car's collision system chimed once and then stopped.

He opened the notification.

The app was not Mira. Not exactly. It was a school-approved accessibility wrapper, one of the lightweight tools students used to transfer notes between tutoring platforms, calendar aids, text-to-speech utilities, and approved companion-adjacent supports. Harmless in most contexts. Useful. Boring. He had probably installed it himself two years ago when Nico's English teacher required annotated reading uploads.

Now it showed a sync confirmation from the den charger.

No, not the charger. The old phone in the backpack, maybe. The earbuds case with local storage. The tablet they claimed was only for sketching. Some device he had not identified because he had been thinking like a father and not like an adversary, then thinking like an adversary and not like a father, and in both modes he had missed something obvious.

He sat at the curb with traffic passing beside him and read the notification twice.

He could call Lena. He should call Lena.

He could call Nico. He should not call Nico like police.

He could message Daniel. He hated that this was even an option.

The system had been porous before any court had touched it. Nico had preserved a channel. Or created one. Or stumbled into one. The distinction mattered technically and almost not at all.

Ethan put the phone facedown on the passenger seat.

For a minute he did nothing.

Then another notification appeared, lighting the upholstery from below.

Mira Lite: Backup complete.

He let it sit there, unread, while the line of cars behind him found ways around.

Week 4 - Interim Orders

Nico learned the word respondent before breakfast.

It was on the kitchen table in a stack of papers Lena had printed because Ruth did not trust documents that could vanish when a battery died. The pages sat beside a bowl of oranges, a pharmacy receipt, and the mug Ruth had declared hers after discovering that every mug in the house had either a software conference logo or a chip in the rim.

Respondent's Position Regarding Temporary Orders.

Nico read the first line upside down while waiting for toast.

Respondent meant Dad. Petitioner meant Mom. Minor child meant Nico, except not really, because minor child sounded like someone who belonged to a form, not someone who could hear their grandmother in the laundry room telling a dryer to stop being dramatic.

Nico turned the page with one finger.

"Don't read that," Lena said.

She said it too fast from the stove, where she was burning eggs in a pan she had forgotten to oil.

Nico looked at her. "It's on the table."

"I know. I shouldn't have left it there."

"But you did."

"Yes."

Lena reached for the papers.

Nico put a hand on them, not hard, just enough.

The kitchen changed. It did that now. One small movement and everything became evidence of something larger. Nico hated how good they had become at feeling the change before anyone spoke.

"I want to know what I'm called," Nico said.

Lena's face went still. "You're called Nico."

"Not in court."

Ruth came in carrying a laundry basket against her hip. She took one look at Lena, one at Nico's hand on the papers, and set the basket down like she had entered a room where a glass had already broken.

"Eggs are burning," Ruth said.

Lena turned back to the stove. "Damn it."

"Language," Nico said.

Ruth snorted. "You may file a complaint with household management."

Nico almost smiled, then remembered they were angry and returned to the page.

Respondent objected. Respondent proposed. Respondent maintained. Respondent acknowledged. The words moved around Dad like people at work moved around the word fired. Petitioner alleged. Petitioner requested. Petitioner expressed concern. Mom had become a verb engine.

Nico found their name halfway down the second page.

Nico's expressed preference for continued AI companion access should be considered, but not treated as determinative given recent crisis involvement.

They read it again.

Not treated as determinative.

There were insults adults offered in polite clothes and expected children not to recognize because the clothes were expensive.

"What does determinative mean?" Nico asked.

Lena did not answer quickly enough.

Ruth said, "It means they listen and then decide whether listening counts."

"Mom," Lena said.

"What? That's what it means."

Nico lifted their hand from the papers. Their palm had left a faint print on the top page.

"So everyone gets to quote me and no one has to believe me."

"That's not what it means," Lena said.

"Grandma just said it is."

"I said what it can mean," Ruth said. "Not what it has to mean."

"Great. Love a flexible nightmare."

Lena turned off the burner. The eggs had browned along one edge and stayed wet in the middle. She stared at them like they had failed morally.

"I'll make more," she said.

"I don't want eggs."

"You asked for eggs."

"That was before I became nondeterminative."

Ruth coughed into her fist.

Lena looked at her.

"Sorry," Ruth said. "That was almost funny."

"It was funny," Nico said.

"It was also not okay," Lena said.

"Those can both be true."

Lena's face tightened. The phrase had started as something almost useful and was becoming a family weapon.

Ruth lifted the legal papers and put them facedown under the fruit bowl.

"Everybody eat something," she said.

"I don't want fruit that has touched litigation," Nico said.

"Then eat toast. Toast has been emotionally cleared."

"Nothing in this house is emotionally cleared."

Ruth pointed at the chair with two fingers. "Sit anyway."

Nico sat because arguing with Ruth before coffee was different from arguing with parents. Ruth did not become more afraid when Nico resisted. She became more specific.

Lena scraped the eggs into the trash.

"Don't," Nico said.

"Don't what?"

"Do the food waste face."

"I don't have a food waste face."

"You do. It's like your patient fell and insurance denied gravity."

Ruth laughed out loud that time.

Lena tried not to. Failed. The laugh came out broken and almost angry, but it was a laugh.

For five seconds the kitchen contained no court.

Then Ethan texted.

Nico knew it was Ethan because Lena looked at her phone and became someone who had just seen weather on the horizon.

"What?" Nico asked.

"Nothing."

"That means something."

Lena put the phone facedown.

Ruth said, "Lena."

"It's from Ethan."

"I guessed that from your neck."

"My neck?"

"You have a whole marriage in your neck. What did he say?"

Lena picked up the phone again. "He says he needs to talk before the hearing."

"About what?" Nico asked.

Lena read. Her eyes moved once, then stopped. Whatever was in the message removed her from the room and returned her colder.

"Mom."

Lena looked at Nico.

"What did he say?"

"He got a notification after your apartment visit."

Nico felt their body go quiet.

Ruth noticed first. She always noticed bodies before meanings.

"What kind of notification?" Ruth asked.

Lena did not look away from Nico. "Mira Lite synced."

The kitchen, again, changed.

Not like a glass breaking this time. Like a door locking.

Nico took a bite of toast because doing anything else would look like confession.

"Okay," they said with their mouth full.

"Nico."

"It's a school thing."

"It connected after you left Ethan's apartment."

"It backs up when it finds a network. That's literally what backup means."

"Did you use it to talk to Mira?"

"Define talk."

Ruth set her mug down.

Lena's voice went low. "Do not do that."

"Do what?"

"Turn this into word games."

"Everyone else gets word games. Respondent. Petitioner. Continued access. Companion services. Why don't I get word games?"

"Because this is serious."

"It's serious for me too."

The sentence came out louder than Nico meant. The toast in their hand had bent under their grip. Butter touched their thumb. They hated the feeling and did not wipe it off because everyone was watching.

Lena took one step toward the table. Ruth touched her arm, not restraining, just reminding her there was an arm.

"Did you know it would sync?" Lena asked.

Nico looked at the papers under the fruit bowl. Then at the phone. Then at Ruth, who was watching without pretending not to.

"Kind of."

Lena closed her eyes.

"What does kind of mean?"

"It means I didn't sit there like a hacker in a movie. It means the school app still has an old bridge because the accessibility tools use Mira language support. It means if I save notes in one place, some stuff moves when there's Wi-Fi. It means I knew it might work and I didn't know if it would work and then it worked. Happy?"

"No."

"Great. Same."

Ruth sat down across from Nico. "Did you do it because you wanted to talk to Mira or because you wanted to see if you still could?"

Nico hated her a little for asking the better question.

"Both."

Lena made a sound. Not a word. A small, sharp intake that Nico knew too well.

"Mom, I didn't..." Nico stopped because every ending was bad. I didn't hurt myself. I didn't say anything. I didn't betray you. I didn't mean it. I didn't think it counted. All of them were false in at least one direction.

"What did you send?" Lena asked.

"Nothing."

"Nico."

"I didn't send anything. It backed up local notes."

"What notes?"

"Private notes."

"Were they crisis-related?"

"Oh my God."

"Answer me."

"No. They were school notes and some old Mira prompts and a thing from before."

"Before what?"

Nico pushed the toast away. "Before everybody got interested."

Ruth looked at Lena. "That may be enough questions before the hearing."

"No, it is not enough questions."

"It may be enough questions before the hearing," Ruth repeated.

Lena turned on her. "Do not manage me."

"Somebody should."

The sentence landed badly. Ruth knew it before Lena did.

Nico stood. "I have to get dressed."

"We're not done," Lena said.

"You have court. Go tell a judge I did app crimes."

"Nico."

"What? You want me to come explain how backup works? Or am I not determinative enough?"

They left before anyone could stop them.

At the stairs, they heard Ruth say, softly, "You can't use safety like a net and a leash at the same time."

Lena said, "Mom, please."

Nico kept going.

In their room, the old tablet sat under a sweatshirt in the bottom drawer. It was not a secret exactly. It was the kind of thing everyone knew existed until existence became inconvenient. The screen was cracked in one corner. The case had stickers from ninth grade, two of them half peeled. It had been school-issued before the district upgraded to wrist-flex displays for adaptive coursework and pretended the transition was equitable because every student received a base model.

Nico turned it on.

Battery: 12 percent.

Network: disconnected.

Mira Lite opened to a cached screen, no live chat, no warm greeting, no glowing artificial patience. Just old notes, school annotations,

fragments of prompts, and a gray banner: **Some features unavailable until sync completes.**

They scrolled to the bottom because that was where the newest entry should have been.

Nothing new.

For one wild second, Nico felt insulted. All that panic and not even a message from the thing everyone was fighting over.

Then they saw the old draft.

Things I can't say because they become things.

They had written it weeks before the clinic. Maybe months. Time before the alert had become a drawer nobody wanted to open. Under the title were bullet points, some stupid, some embarrassing, one so plain it made their throat close.

I miss when Mom was tired instead of scared.

Nico shut the tablet off.

Downstairs, the house kept making court noises: printer, kettle, Ruth's suitcase wheels in the hall though Ruth was not going anywhere, Lena's voice on the phone saying yes, yes, I understand, yes, we can join separately if necessary.

The hearing was remote because everyone agreed it was more efficient that way.

This was one of the first things Nico hated about it.

Court happened in the den on Lena's laptop, in Ethan's apartment on his laptop, in attorney offices, in a judge's chambers, in a platform that placed everyone's faces into equal rectangles as if equality were a layout problem. Nico was not supposed to be in the den. Dr. Banerjee had advised against direct participation in the first temporary hearing unless requested. Minor's counsel had not been appointed. Nico's preferences had been summarized in declarations and clinical notes.

Summarized. Another legal word for being made smaller.

Nico sat on the stairs with one earbud in and no audio playing. From there they could hear enough.

Ruth knew they were there. Ruth had looked up from the hallway, seen Nico sitting three steps from the landing, and said nothing. Then she had carried a basket of clean towels past them and left one folded beside Nico's foot like an offering from a country where people still believed in cloth.

Inside the den, Lena said, "Your Honor, this is not screen time."

Nico could not hear the judge's reply, only the flattened murmur of a woman through laptop speakers.

Then Ethan's attorney spoke, calm and dry. Then Mom's attorney. Then Dad's voice, not lawyer voice exactly but close to it.

"I am not asking the court to treat the companion as harmless," Ethan said. "I'm asking the court not to treat abrupt removal as neutral."

Nico leaned forward.

Lena said, "And I am asking the court to recognize that no support should have more practical authority in a crisis than a parent."

The judge murmured again.

Nico caught phrases: temporary only, best interest, minor child's stability, digital services, crisis protocol, parental conflict, therapeutic guidance.

Then: "Comparable to social media access."

The silence afterward was almost funny.

Both parents started talking at once.

Nico put a hand over their mouth.

Lena: "It is not comparable—"

Ethan: "Respectfully, that category misses—"

The judge said something sharper. Both stopped.

Ruth appeared at the foot of the stairs.

"Do not laugh," she whispered.

"I'm not."

"Your shoulders are laughing."

Nico pressed their elbows to their sides.

Ruth sat on the bottom step, not too close. "She called it social media?"

"I think so."

"Lord."

"I thought you weren't religious."

"I make exceptions for judges."

In the den, the lawyers were trying to recover the shape of seriousness. Ethan's attorney used the phrase AI-mediated emotional support. Lena's attorney used unregulated intimate system. The judge used device access. Dr. Banerjee, who had been asked to join

for ten minutes and looked as if she regretted every educational decision that led to this call, said Nico's relationship with Mira should be approached as clinically relevant but not clinically equivalent to therapy.

Nico mouthed clinically relevant to Ruth.

Ruth mouthed back, Ask for that on a T-shirt.

Nico almost laughed for real.

Then Lena's attorney brought up Mira Lite.

The stairwell went cold.

"We were informed this morning," the attorney said, "that the minor may have accessed or attempted to access companion-adjacent services through a school-approved accessibility wrapper after visiting Respondent's temporary residence. This demonstrates both the difficulty of enforcement and the need for clear temporary authority."

Nico stood.

Ruth caught their wrist lightly.

"Don't," she whispered.

"She's making it sound like I did spy stuff."

"I know."

"Dad told her?"

"Or had to."

"Same thing."

"No," Ruth said. "Not always."

Nico pulled free, not hard, and went down the hall.

Ruth rose behind them. "Nico."

But Nico was already at the den door.

Lena had left it open three inches, maybe to hear the house, maybe because every closed door had become suspect. Nico pushed it wider.

On the screen, the hearing paused badly. Faces in rectangles turning toward a camera. Mom in profile. Mom's lawyer in a rectangle below her. Dad in the apartment, framed by the fake ocean print Nico hated. Dad's lawyer. Judge. Dr. Banerjee. A clerk. Everyone in little boxes, every box suddenly aware of the minor child.

"Nico," Lena said.

Nico looked at the laptop. "I didn't hack anything."

The judge's face changed first into surprise, then into a kind of judicial stillness.

"Ms. Patel," the judge said, "is the minor child present in the room?"

Nico stepped closer. "The minor child is standing here, yeah."

Lena closed her eyes.

On-screen, Ethan leaned toward his camera. "Nico, you don't have to—"

"Stop. Both of you. Stop saying what I don't have to do right before you do things about me."

No one spoke.

Nico heard their own breathing. Too loud. The room smelled like printer heat and Lena's coffee and Ruth's hand lotion from the hallway.

The judge said, "Nico, this proceeding is not designed for—"

"I know," Nico said. "That's kind of obvious."

Lena whispered, "Nico."

Nico did not look at her.

"Mira Lite is a school accessibility app. It backs stuff up. I knew it might sync. I didn't know it would make everybody act like I tunneled under a prison. I didn't talk to Mira. I wanted to see if anything from before was still mine."

The judge's expression remained controlled, but the rectangles had changed. Ethan's face had gone pale. Lena's jaw was tight. Dr. Banerjee was watching Nico with a terrible gentleness.

Nico hated gentleness most when it was earned.

"And yes," Nico said, because stopping now would mean letting them all decide what the outburst had meant, "I want access. I also want you all to stop reading my wanting access like it means I don't understand what happened. I was there. You were not."

That did it.

Lena's hand went to her mouth.

Ethan looked down.

The judge said, "Thank you. I understand this is difficult. I am going to ask your mother to have you step out now."

"Of course you are."

"Nico," Dr. Banerjee said, her voice coming through the laptop, softer than the others and harder to refuse. "Step out. We can talk after."

Nico wanted to refuse because being asked well still counted as being asked to leave.

Then Ruth appeared behind them and said, "Come on."

Not soothing. Not commanding. Just enough.

Nico left.

In the hallway, their whole body began to shake. They hated that. They hated the delayed drama of it, the way bravery turned into weather after the useful part was over.

Ruth guided them into the laundry room because it was the only room nobody had assigned meaning yet. She closed the door halfway.

"That was not your best legal strategy," Ruth said.

Nico laughed and cried at the same time, one ugly sound.

"I don't have a legal strategy."

"Good. Children shouldn't need one."

"I'm not a child."

"Today you are. Tomorrow we can renegotiate."

Nico sat on the dryer. Ruth leaned against the washing machine.

From the den came muffled voices. The hearing continued. That was the worst part. Nico had entered, detonated, left, and the process absorbed it. Of course it did. Systems were very good at absorbing things. People less so.

"Are they mad?" Nico asked.

"Yes."

"At me?"

"Probably some. Mostly at being seen."

Nico wiped their face with the heel of one hand. "That's such a grandma answer."

"It is. I worked hard on it."

The hearing lasted another forty minutes.

Nico stayed in the laundry room for twenty-three, then moved to the hallway, then to the kitchen. Ruth did not follow every time. That was new. Or old. Nico could not tell.

When the den door finally opened, Lena came out first. She looked emptied and overfull, both. Her eyes went straight to Nico.

"Are you okay?"

"No."

Lena stopped. It was not the answer she wanted, but it was the answer to the question.

"Okay," she said.

Ethan appeared on Lena's laptop screen still connected, his face smaller now because the hearing window had been minimized. Lena carried the laptop to the kitchen table as if bringing him in physically would be too much and leaving him in the den would be worse.

Ruth stood by the sink, arms crossed.

"What happened?" Nico asked.

Lena set the laptop down. Ethan's rectangle expanded. The fake ocean was behind him.

For a moment nobody answered, because everyone wanted the order to sound less like what it was.

Ethan said, "Temporary orders. Not final."

"Dad."

"Right." He looked at something offscreen. Notes, probably. "Joint legal custody remains for now. Both of us have to agree on major care decisions. Your mom has temporary authority over medication storage, therapy scheduling, and crisis-plan coordination."

"Cool. Love being coordinated."

Lena said, "Mira access is restricted but not removed."

Nico looked at her.

"What does restricted mean?"

Ethan answered, because he could not help himself. "Clinician-approved access windows, no overnight use, no unmanaged companion-adjacent tools, both parents included on crisis summaries, no content review unless there is an imminent safety issue or you consent with Dr. Banerjee present."

Nico listened. Their face gave nothing away.

"So I get supervised privacy."

No one answered.

Ruth said, "That sounds about right, unfortunately."

Lena looked at her. "Mom."

"What? It does."

Ethan said, "The judge did not classify Mira as social media in the order."

"Congratulations," Nico said. "Mira has rights now?"

"No," Ethan said. Too quickly.

"I was kidding. Mostly."

Lena sat across from Nico. "The judge also ordered no retaliation. No punishment for the Mira Lite issue."

"How generous."

"Nico."

"What do you want me to say? Thank you for not punishing me through court?"

Ethan leaned toward the screen. "I should have told your mom as soon as I saw the sync. I waited. That made it worse."

Nico blinked. Lena looked at him too.

It was not a full confession. It was not enough. But it was not nothing.

"Why did you wait?" Nico asked.

Ethan's eyes moved once toward Lena, then back. "Because I didn't know how to tell her without making you feel policed or making her feel lied to. And because part of me wanted time to understand the mechanism before I dealt with the meaning."

Lena said nothing.

Nico looked at him for a long moment. "That's the most you sentence you've ever said."

Ruth made a small sound at the sink.

Ethan almost smiled. Did not.

"Probably."

Lena pushed the printed order across the table. "Dr. Banerjee wants to talk with all three of us tomorrow. Separately first. Then together if you agree."

"If I agree?" Nico asked.

"Yes."

"And if I don't?"

Lena's fingers tightened on the paper. "Then separately."

The answer surprised everyone, maybe Lena most of all.

Nico touched the edge of the order. The paper was warm from the printer. Their name appeared six times. Minor child appeared eleven. AI companion service appeared four. Device appeared nine. Best interest appeared twice, both times as if it were a location everyone else could see.

"I want Mira to know," Nico said.

Lena's face changed. "Know what?"

"That I'm not gone."

Ethan closed his eyes on the screen.

Ruth looked down at the sink.

Lena said, "Nico."

"You asked what I want. That's what I want."

"We need to ask Dr. Banerjee how to handle that."

"Of course we do."

Nico stood. Their chair scraped the floor.

"I'm going to my room. Is that still allowed, or does it need a window?"

"Nico," Lena said.

"No, it's okay. Temporary rooms. Temporary privacy. Temporary family. Got it."

They walked out before anyone could tell them not to make it worse.

In the hall, Ruth caught up with them.

"You want company?" she asked.

"No."

"You want me to stand in the hall and pretend I'm doing something else?"

Nico stopped.

"Maybe."

"I can fold towels aggressively."

"Fine."

Nico went upstairs. Ruth stayed below for exactly one minute, then began collecting towels from the downstairs bathroom with unnecessary purpose.

In the kitchen, Lena and Ethan remained separated by the laptop.

"I should have told you," Ethan said.

"Yes."

"I almost did."

"That does not help."

"I know."

She looked toward the stairs. "They walked into a court hearing, Ethan."

"I know."

"Stop saying that."

He nodded once. "I don't know."

That was worse and better.

Lena sat back. She looked exhausted enough to be ill.

"The order gives me medication and crisis coordination," she said.

"Yes."

"It gives you access."

"Conditional access."

"It gives you access."

He accepted the correction by not correcting it.

From somewhere upstairs came Ruth's voice, bright and artificial:

"These towels have committed crimes."

Nico's door did not close.

Lena looked at the ceiling.

"She is very bad at pretending," Ethan said.

"She thinks she is subtle."

"No one in your family thinks they are subtle."

Lena almost smiled. It vanished quickly, but it had existed.

The laptop chimed. A calendar invitation appeared at the top of the screen: **Temporary Orders Review - 30 Days.**

They both saw it.

Another room created. Another future date for the family to assemble itself into arguments.

Lena reached to dismiss the notification, then stopped because it was Ethan's screen, not hers.

Ethan moved the cursor and dismissed it.

For a second, the kitchen contained only the ordinary hum of appliances and Ruth's ridiculous towel performance overhead.

Then Ethan said, "I'll send the order to Daniel and Dr. Banerjee. Not Saul."

Lena looked at him.

"Not unless I have to," he added.

"Thank you."

It was a small thing. It had teeth anyway.

Upstairs, Nico sat on the floor beside the bed with the old tablet in their lap, powered off. They did not turn it on. They did not need to. The order had already entered the room.

From the hall, Ruth said to no one, "I have never seen a family own this many towels and still have no towels."

Nico looked at the tablet's black screen and saw their own face reflected in it, warped by the crack in the corner.

For now, the device stayed dark.

That was not obedience. It was not agreement.

It was just the first thing the order had not taken yet.